

THE RULES

A lean D&D-style tabletop RPG, in sixteen chapters

V1 · FOR PERSONAL USE

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00 — Design Philosophy

This is the document every other document in this game answers to. When a later rule feels wrong, check it against this one.

What this game is

A standalone tabletop RPG in the D&D tradition. Same shape: a party of heroes, a Game Master running the world, d20 rolls, classes, spells, monsters, levels. Different size: roughly **one-third the rules** of D&D 5e, with no loss of the things that make a campaign feel like a campaign.

It is **not** a one-shot board game and **not** a 5e supplement. Someone who has never played a tabletop RPG should be able to read this rulebook and run a campaign. Someone who knows 5e should be able to read it in under an hour and feel oriented.

The three design goals, in order

1. **A new player can play their first turn correctly within 10 minutes of sitting down.** Not "understand the rules" — *play correctly*. This is the test every rule has to pass.
2. **The game still rewards system mastery.** Character choices matter. Tactics matter. Spell selection matters. We are stripping rules, not stripping depth.
3. **A GM can run a session with five minutes of prep.** Stat blocks fit on an index card. Encounter math is mental math. Rulings are faster than lookups.

When these three goals conflict, **goal 1 wins**. A rule that gives veteran players a juicy tactical option but slows down a newcomer's first turn is a bad rule for this game.

What we are cutting, and why

These are 5e features (and broader D&D-tradition features) we are explicitly removing. Each cut has a reason; if a later doc wants to add one back, it has to argue against the reason.

Cut	Reason
The action / bonus action / reaction split	Three resources for "what you do on your turn" is two too many. One action per turn, with named exceptions.
Opportunity attacks as a default rule	Slows every movement decision. Becomes an optional condition.
Spell slot ladder (1st–9th level slots)	Replaced with a flatter resource. See 09-magic.md.
Concentration as a tracked status	Replaced with simpler "only one active spell at a time" framing.
Attunement	Doesn't exist. Magic items have their effect or they don't.
Encumbrance and carrying capacity	Doesn't exist. Carry what's reasonable; GM calls absurdities.
Racial subraces (Hill Dwarf vs. Mountain Dwarf, etc.)	One version of each ancestry.
Feats as a parallel progression system	Folded into class features. No feat tax.
Multiclassing	Doesn't exist as a system. Re flavor a class instead.
Six ability scores with score/modifier distinction	Collapsed. See 02-character-creation.md.
Skill list of 18 named skills	Collapsed into a smaller set tied directly to ability scores.
Death saving throws as a mini-game	Replaced with a simpler downed state. See 07-hp-damage-death.md.
Tracking spell components, material costs	Doesn't exist. If a spell needs a thing, the spell says so in its text.
Short rest vs. long rest distinction	One rest type. See 03-progression.md.
Exhaustion levels 1–6	Replaced with a single Exhausted condition.
Hit dice as a separate healing resource	Healing comes from rests and spells. No third system.
Counting cantrip damage dice that scale at levels 5/11/17	Cantrips have one damage line. They get better when you level the class.

The pattern: **anything that adds a conditional modifier, a separate resource pool, or a sub-mini-game gets cut unless it earns its keep.**

What we are protecting

Cuts are easy; what's harder is being clear about what we will *not* compromise. If a simplification threatens these, the simplification loses.

- **The d20 moment.** The game's heartbeat is rolling a d20 against a target number and reacting to what it shows. This stays untouched. No dice pools, no 2d6 curves.
- **Class identity.** A fighter, a wizard, a rogue, and a cleric have to *feel* mechanically different on turn one of level one. Not just re flavored.
- **Tactical combat.** Position, choice of target, choice of action — these still matter. We are not narrating combat into oblivion.

- **Spells you recognize.** Fireball, Cure Wounds, Shield, Magic Missile, Charm Person — the iconic spells survive, possibly renamed, mechanically simpler.
- **Character growth across a campaign.** Level 1 and level 20 characters are clearly different. Leveling is a moment, not a paperwork session.
- **GM authority.** The GM rules edge cases on the spot. The book doesn't try to anticipate everything.

Design principles every other doc must follow

These are the rules the *rules* follow. If a later document violates one of these, it's the document that's wrong.

1. Small numbers, always

Bonuses and penalties are usually +1, +2, or +3. We don't stack five different +1s on a roll. **If you can't do the math in your head while drunk, it's too much math.** Target the player who never wants to look at a character sheet mid-turn.

2. One rule, not three

If a situation has three possible resolutions in 5e (action vs. bonus action vs. reaction; spell save vs. attack roll vs. auto-hit), this game picks one. Variety lives in *content* (different spells, different monsters), not in *meta-rules*.

3. Symmetry between players and monsters

A monster's attack works the same way as a player's attack. A monster's "save" works the same way as a player's check. There is no separate sub-system for the GM side of the screen. This halves what a new GM has to learn.

4. The d20 carries the variance

We use the d20 spread on purpose: a 1 should sometimes ruin a strong character's plan, and a 20 should sometimes save a weak one. Don't paper over that swing with floors, ceilings, or rerolls. RNG is a feature.

5. If it doesn't change the decision, cut it

A rule earns its place only if it changes what a player chooses to do. A +1 modifier that the player would have applied to whatever they were going to do anyway is fake complexity. Cut it.

6. Rulings over rules

When the rule is unclear or missing, the GM picks something sensible and the game continues. The rulebook does not need to cover the edge case. The GM does not need to feel guilty about deciding. **A consistent ruling beats a correct one.**

7. Teachable in 30 seconds

For every rule, ask: can a player explain it to a new player in 30 seconds at the table, without looking at the book? If no, the rule is too big. Either shrink it or cut it.

8. No bookkeeping the players don't enjoy

Players enjoy tracking HP and spells. They don't enjoy tracking rations, arrows, torch durations, or encumbrance. We track the first kind. We don't track the second.

The complexity budget

Total rulebook target: **roughly 60 pages of actual rules**, plus reference content (spell list, bestiary, equipment).

Per-doc soft caps:

- Core mechanic, character creation, combat: aim for 4–6 pages each.
- Magic: aim for 8 pages (the most expensive system).
- Everything else: 2–4 pages.

If a doc blows its budget, that's a signal we've over-designed the system, not a signal the budget was wrong. Cut first.

How we'll know it's working

The game is succeeding if:

- A first-time player makes their character in 15 minutes.
- A first-time GM runs a fight without flipping back to the book.
- A combat round between four players and three monsters takes under 10 minutes.
- "What does my character do?" has an obvious answer almost every turn.
- The book fits in a tab in someone's browser, not a binder on their desk.

The game is failing if:

- Players are asking "wait, can I also do X?" every turn.
- The GM is doing arithmetic between every action.
- Anyone says "let me look that up" more than once a fight.
- A new player needs a veteran to translate their character sheet.

The contract with the rest of these docs

Every other document in this directory is downstream of this one. When you read 05-combat.md or 09-magic.md, you should be able to point at any rule and trace it back to a principle here. If you can't, the rule is suspect — or this doc is missing something and needs updating.

We will revise this document as we go. It is the spec, not a manifesto.

01 — The Core Mechanic

This is the only resolution rule in the game. Combat, magic, sneaking, lying, climbing, picking a lock, resisting a curse — all of them are the rule below with different numbers plugged in.

The rule

When you try something that could fail and matters, roll a d20, add one modifier, and compare it to a target number. Meet or beat the number: you succeed. Miss it: you fail.

That is the entire game. Everything that follows is a clarification of one of those four pieces: *when you roll*, *what modifier*, *what target number*, *what happens on a 1 or 20*.

Target numbers

The GM tells you what target number you're rolling against. There are three:

Difficulty	Target	Feel
Easy	10	A trained person succeeds most of the time. An untrained person has a real chance.
Hard	15	The right tool for the job; failure is plausible.
Heroic	20	A story-worthy feat. Even an expert can blow it.

That is the whole scale. The GM may go to **5** for trivial-but-not-automatic, or **25** for legendary, but in practice almost every roll in the game is 10, 15, or 20.

If the GM is unsure, the answer is **15**. Default to Hard and adjust by feel.

When *not* to roll

The GM does not call for a roll when:

- Success is the only outcome that makes sense given the character's training. (*A trained thief opens an ordinary house lock without dice.*)
- Failure is the only outcome that makes sense. (*A barbarian with no magical training cannot decipher the rune by rolling well.*)
- The roll would not change the story regardless of result.

Roll only when the outcome is in doubt and the result will matter in the next minute of play. This is not advice; it is a rule. Calling for unnecessary rolls is the single biggest source of slowdown at the table.

Modifiers

Two things, at most, get added to your d20.

1. **Your ability modifier** for whichever ability the task uses. Ability modifiers range from **-1 to +5** across the entire game. (See 02-character-creation.md for the abilities themselves.)
2. **Your training bonus**, if your character is trained in this kind of task. The training bonus is **+2 at low levels, +3 at mid levels, +4 at high levels**. You either have it or you don't — no half-training, no expertise tiers.

That is the entire modifier stack. **A character's bonus on any roll is somewhere between -1 and +9 for the whole life of the game.** No situational +1 s, no flanking bonus, no bardic inspiration math, no stacked buffs that turn the turn into arithmetic.

Principle: if a feature would add yet another +1 , it instead grants **advantage** (below). Modifiers are reserved for who the character *is*; advantage is reserved for the situation they're *in*.

The natural 20 and the natural 1

These check the d20 itself, before modifiers.

- **Natural 20** is the best possible outcome the situation allows. In combat, this is a **critical hit**: roll your damage dice twice and add them together (modifiers added only once). Outside combat, the GM narrates a result better than the player asked for — extra information, an additional benefit, a stroke of luck on top.
- **Natural 1** is the worst possible outcome. In combat, you miss *and* something bad happens — you drop the weapon, expose a flank, hit an ally. Outside combat, you fail *and* introduce a complication.

A natural 1 is not "you take the modifier off and check the total against the target." It is an automatic, dramatic failure. The d20 is allowed to ruin your day. That's the contract — the game keeps variance interesting by letting it actually matter.

Advantage and disadvantage

This is the one situational modifier in the game. It replaces every other "circumstance bonus" you might think of.

- **Advantage:** roll **two** d20s, use the **higher** one.
- **Disadvantage:** roll **two** d20s, use the **lower** one.

Rules:

- You either have advantage or you don't. Multiple sources of advantage don't stack.
- One source of advantage and one source of disadvantage **cancel each other**, and you roll a normal single d20. It doesn't matter how many of each — any of one cancels any of the other.

Anywhere in this rulebook, when a rule could have said `+2 in this situation` , it instead says `advantage in this situation` . That is the design substitution. You will see it constantly.

One roll per action: the active player rolls

This game has **no contested rolls** and **no saving throws against attacks**. Whoever is taking the action makes the only roll.

- A fighter swinging a sword: the fighter rolls vs. the target's **Armor** defense.
- A wizard casting a mind-control spell: the wizard rolls vs. the target's **Mind** defense.
- A rogue trying to sneak past a guard: the rogue rolls vs. the guard's **Awareness**.
- A monster biting a player: the monster rolls vs. the player's Armor defense.

Defenses are static numbers on the character sheet. They don't roll; they are rolled *against*. This is symmetric: a player's attack and a monster's attack use the exact same procedure. There is no separate "saving throw" subsystem to learn.

The exception is at the GM's discretion: **when neither side is really "acting" and both are equally engaged** (an arm-wrestling match, two scouts trying to spot each other first), the GM may call for both sides to roll and compare totals. This should be rare. Default to one roll.

Group rolls

When a whole party tries the same thing (sneaking together, climbing the same cliff), they don't make four separate rolls. Use the **weakest-link** rule:

- Everyone rolls.
- If **half or more** of the party succeeds, the group succeeds. Those who failed are carried/covered by those who succeeded.
- Otherwise the group fails, and the GM picks one of the failed rolls to drive the complication.

This is faster than tracking each character separately and produces the right dramatic outcomes: a single failure doesn't doom a competent party, but a party that's mostly weak at something gets caught.

What rolls *aren't* for

A few things the d20 deliberately does not decide:

- **Reading a clue the GM has written into the world.** If there's a letter under the floorboard and the player says they look under the floorboard, they find the letter. No Perception check.
- **Recalling something the character would obviously know.** A wizard knows what a goblin is. A cleric knows the major gods. No roll.
- **What the player decides to do.** The d20 resolves attempts, not intentions. A bad roll means the *attempt* failed, not that the *plan* was stupid.

When in doubt: the d20 is for **moments of pressure with real stakes**, not for testing whether the character is allowed to perceive their own surroundings.

A worked example

The party is sneaking up on a bandit camp at night. The rogue (Stealth-trained, Agility +3) tries to slip into the tent. The bandit lieutenant's Awareness is 14.

- The GM does **not** ask the bandit to roll. The lieutenant is not acting; the rogue is.
- The rogue rolls **d20 + 3 (Agility) + 2 (training)** vs. **14**.
- They get an 11 on the die. Total: **16**. Beat 14. They're in the tent.

Now the rogue tries to memorize the map on the table. The GM says this is **Easy (10)** — the map is right there, no one is watching, there's just enough light. The rogue rolls **d20 + 3 (Intellect)**, no training in cartography. They get a **2** on the die. Natural 1? No, just a low result. Total **5**. They miss the location of the next ambush.

If they had rolled a natural **1**: they knock over a lantern and the camp wakes up. If they had rolled a natural **20**: they memorize the map *and* notice a second map hidden under it.

That's the whole loop. Roll, modifier, target, narration.

Why this is enough

A first-time player needs to learn exactly one sentence to play this game competently:

"Roll a d20, add my modifier, beat the number the GM gives me."

Critical hits, advantage, group rolls, defenses — all of those are elaborations the player can absorb during their first session of play. None of them block the first turn. That's the design target from oo-design-philosophy.md, and this mechanic hits it.

Everything else in this rulebook — combat, magic, character creation, monsters — is just a list of *which ability*, *which target*, and *what happens after the roll resolves*.

02 — Character Creation

A character has five abilities, one class, one ancestry, one background, and three trainings. Everything else flows from those choices. Total time to make a character: **15 minutes**.

The five abilities

Every character has five ability scores. Each is a single number, a modifier, ranging from **-1** to **+5**. There is no separate "score 8–20" tracked behind the modifier — the modifier is the ability.

Ability	What it covers
Might	Strength, toughness, raw physical force. Hitting hard with heavy weapons. Wrestling, breaking down doors, soaking damage. Drives HP.
Agility	Speed, balance, finesse, reflexes. Hitting with light or ranged weapons. Sneaking, dodging, climbing, picking locks. Drives Armor for the unarmored or lightly armored.
Mind	Reasoning, memory, study, perception of detail. Spotting traps, recalling lore, reading languages. Drives studied (arcane) magic.
Spirit	Willpower, faith, intuition, the soul's bond to the unseen. Resisting possession, death-magic, and the sacred-gone-wrong; sensing what's holy. Drives divine / primal magic.
Charisma	Presence, force of personality, performance. Persuading, leading, deceiving, intimidating. Holding your composure against charm and fear. Drives innate magic — sorcery, pact, and song.

Mind / Spirit / Charisma — the three caster abilities. All three fuel magic and each anchors a defense (below). They divide by *source*: Mind is **studied** (you learned it), Spirit is **devoted** (it was granted), Charisma is **innate** (it pours out of you). A class's **pool** is one of these three.

A roll's ability is whichever **best fits the action** — the GM picks. A barbarian climbing a wall by force uses Might. A scout climbing the same wall by balance uses Agility. Talking your way past the guard is Charisma; staring him down is Charisma too. Don't argue about which it is; pick one and roll.

Generating your abilities

No dice. **Assign +3, +2, +1, +1, +0** to your five abilities, one each. That's the entire procedure. (*Five abilities, so one more +1 than the old four-ability array — you'll still be bad at something.*)

Your class and ancestry will then modify these (see below). You will almost never have a starting ability above **+4** or below **+0**.

Class

A class is a **combination of components** — weapon types, an armor tier, and (for casters) schools of magic. Pick one of the **48 classes** in 19-classes.md; there is no multiclassing and there are no subclasses, because the combinations *are* the variety. Re flavor freely.

Your class gives you:

- **Training** in its weapon types, armor tier, and (casters) spellcasting.
- A **suggested primary ability** — Might or Agility for fighters, by feel; Mind, Spirit, or Charisma (the **pool**) for casters.
- An **HP tier**, set by armor:

Armor tier	Starting HP	Picks
Heavy	10 + Might	2 weapon/school picks
Light	8 + Might	2 picks
None (naked)	6 + Might	3 picks

- A **unique Class Signature** at level 1, plus **component perk tracks** you unlock as you level. Each of your 3 components is a 2-perk track (a basic perk and an advanced one), so your full kit is **6 perks** by the master tier — gained one at a time (03-progression.md). All perks and the 48 Class Signatures live in 19-classes.md.
- **Casters:** a mana pool of `level + pool` (Mind, Spirit, *or* Charisma), `2` cantrips + the spells-known table (09-magic.md), drawn from your class's accessible **schools** (10-spell-list.md). Cast freely in light or no armor; heavy armor blocks casting.

The old four — Warrior, Scout, Mage, Priest — survive exactly, as the **Knight, Ranger, Mage**, and **Priest** entries of the roster. Nothing is lost; everything is generalized.

Every build is exactly 3 components. You start with **2 Signatures** (Racial + Class) and unlock **6 component perks** over the campaign. That's the balance spine — every character of a given level has the same number of abilities, so balance stays checkable by counting (balance-notes.md).

Ancestry

Pick one. Each grants an ability bump and one mechanical trait — **your Racial Signature**, one of your two level-1 signatures. No subraces, no half-versions.

Ancestry	Ability	Trait
Human	+1 to any ability of your choice	Adaptable — pick a 4th training at character creation.
Elf	+1 Agility	Keen Senses — advantage on Perception rolls. You can see clearly in dim light.
Dwarf	+1 Might	Stone-Hearted — advantage on Charisma defense against fear and charm. You can see in total darkness up to 30 ft.
Halfling	+1 Agility	Lucky — once per rest, reroll any one d20 of yours and take the new result.
Orc	+1 Might	Savage Reserves — once per rest, when you drop to 0 HP, you instead drop to 1 HP.
Goblin	+1 Agility	Scurry — your speed is 8 squares (40 ft) instead of 6. You can move through spaces of creatures larger than you.

This is the whole list. The GM is free to invent new ancestries that follow the same template: one ability +1, one trait of comparable power.

Background

Pick a short phrase that describes who your character was before they started adventuring. It grants **one additional training** of your choice. The phrase has no mechanical effect beyond that — but the GM will use it to seed hooks, NPCs, and roleplay opportunities for you.

Examples: *Disgraced knight. Tavern brawler. Forest hermit. Temple acolyte. Reformed thief. Tribal hunter. Failed apprentice. Mercenary lieutenant.*

Trainings

Trainings are the only "skill" mechanic in the game. Each training is a tag. When you roll for something your training covers, you add your **training bonus** (+2 at levels 1–7, +3 at levels 8–14, +4 at levels 15–20). When you roll for something your training doesn't cover, you don't. There are no half-trainings.

The GM decides whether a training applies. If it's a stretch, the GM may rule "yes, but with disadvantage" or "no, but with advantage to convince me."

The full training list:

Training	What it covers
Acrobatics	Tumbling, balance, jumping, falling well.
Arcana	Identifying spells, magical traditions, arcane creatures.
Athletics	Climbing, swimming, jumping, grappling, raw physical feats.
Crafting	Making, repairing, identifying mundane objects and traps.
Endurance	Long marches, holding your breath, resisting environmental damage.
Insight	Reading intent, spotting lies, gauging mood.
Intimidation	Threatening, demoralizing, breaking will.
Investigation	Searching, deducing, piecing together evidence.
Lore	History, geography, languages, written knowledge.
Medicine	Diagnosing, stabilizing the dying, identifying poisons.
Perception	Spotting, hearing, sensing what's wrong.
Persuasion	Convincing, bargaining, charming.
Religion	Gods, rites, undead, divine creatures, holy places.
Sleight of Hand	Picking pockets, palming, defeating small mechanisms.
Stealth	Hiding, moving silently, avoiding notice.
Tactics	Reading a battlefield, anticipating enemy moves, command.
Wilderness	Tracking, foraging, weather, beasts, navigation.

You pick **three trainings total** at character creation: two from your class list, one from your background. (A Human ancestry adds a fourth.)

Defenses

Four defenses, derived from your abilities. They are static numbers attackers roll against. The three mental defenses are symmetric — each caster ability is both a *pool* and a *defense*.

- **Armor** = $10 + \text{Agility} + \text{armor bonus}$ (or $10 + \text{Might} + \text{armor bonus}$ if wearing heavy armor) — physical hits, most elemental blasts.
- **Mind** = $10 + \text{Mind}$ — attacks on the senses and intellect: illusion, sleep, psychic, paralysis, domination.
- **Spirit** = $10 + \text{Spirit}$ — attacks on the soul and life-force: banishment, death-magic, possession, holy/unholy wrath.
- **Charisma** = $10 + \text{Charisma}$ — attacks on composure and will: charm, fear, command, taunt.

Armor bonuses come from your armor's **material** (light = leather/hide, Agility-based; heavy = metal/stone, Might-based) — see 18-armor.md. At level 1, your Mind / Spirit / Charisma defenses sit around 9–14 ; your Armor depends on what you wear — typically 15–18 for an armored character, 11–13 for an unarmored caster (see 18-armor.md).

Step-by-step

1. **Assign abilities.** Distribute +3 , +2 , +1 , +1 , +0 across Might, Agility, Mind, Spirit, Charisma.
2. **Pick a class** (19-classes.md). Apply its +1 to your **primary ability**; note your HP tier, your **Class Signature**, the component perk tracks you'll unlock, and (casters) your pool and schools.
3. **Pick an ancestry.** Apply its +1 bonus and note its trait — your **Racial Signature**.
4. **Pick a background.** A phrase (grants one training).
5. **Pick three trainings** from the full list below (a fourth if Human) — two themed to your class, one from your background.
6. **Calculate defenses.** Armor, Mind, Spirit, Charisma per the formulas above.
7. **Buy equipment.** Use the starting kits in 11-equipment.md, or buy à la carte from a starting purse of 50 gold (materials in 17-weapons.md / 18-armor.md).
8. **Pick spells if a caster.** Cantrips + spells from your accessible **schools** (10-spell-list.md).
9. **Name your character.** Decide one thing they love, one thing they fear, and one thing they're hiding.

Worked example: Brenna the Ranger

A halfling poacher who fled her village after stealing from the lord's hunting lodge.

1. **Abilities.** +3 Agility , +2 Mind , +1 Might , +1 Charisma , +0 Spirit .
2. **Class: Ranger** (Light + Ranged weapons · Light armor · primary Agility). +1 Agility → +4 . HP tier (light) $8 + \text{Might } 1 = 9$. **Class Signature: Hunter's Mark** (level 1). Her component tracks — Light (Sneak Strike → Shadowstrike), Ranged (Deadeye → Piercing Volley), Light armor (Slip Away → Evasion) — unlock one perk at a time as she levels.
3. **Ancestry: Halfling.** +1 Agility → final Agility +5 . **Racial Signature: Lucky** — one reroll per rest.
4. **Background: Poacher.**
5. **Trainings. Stealth, Wilderness** (class), **Sleight of Hand** (background).
6. **Defenses.** Armor $10 + 5 + 2$ (Leather, light) = 17 . Mind $10 + 2 = 12$. Spirit $10 + 0 = 10$. Charisma $10 + 1 = 11$.
7. **Equipment.** Iron longbow, two Iron daggers, Leather armor, 20 arrows, climbing rope, 5 gold.
8. **N/A** — not a caster.
9. **Name.** *Brenna Quickfoot*. Loves the open road. Fears being recognized. Hides the lord's signet ring in her boot.

Total time: about ten minutes. Brenna is ready to play. Her sheet is one index card.

What characters don't have

To save time and rule cuts, characters do not have:

- Alignment.
- A racial language list. (You speak Common and one regional language; if it matters, the GM will tell you.)
- An age, height, or weight stat block. (Fictional only, never mechanical.)
- Encumbrance or carrying capacity. (You carry what's reasonable. The GM calls absurdity.)

- A list of starting proficiencies separate from trainings. (Trainings *are* proficiencies.)
- Hit dice. (Healing comes from rests and spells, see 07-hp-damage-death.md.)
- Spell components, somatic/verbal/material distinctions, or material cost tracking.

If you find yourself reaching for a 5e-style rule that isn't here, the answer is almost always: "it doesn't exist, just describe what you're doing." That's not a bug — it's the design.

03 — Progression

Characters grow from level 1 to level 20. By the master tier, the party are legends shaping the fate of a region or a world.

The shape of leveling is a **three-beat cycle** — *Ability* → *Perk* → *Breadth* — so every level-up hands you exactly one headline change, plus HP. You never look at a level-up and feel nothing happened, and you never get buried in choices at once.

Two kinds of "special ability"

The game keeps these cleanly separate:

- **Signatures (2).** Your **Racial Signature** and your **Class Signature** — the unique, identity-defining moves. You get **both at level 1** and they never change (your Class Signature *ascends* to a stronger version at the level-20 capstone). See 19-classes.md.
- **Perks (6).** The mechanical abilities granted by your **components** (weapon types, armor tier, schools). Each component is a **2-perk track** (a basic perk and an advanced one); you **unlock them as you level**, not all at once.

So a level-1 character has **2 signatures**. A level-20 character has **2 signatures + 6 perks + a capstone = 9 marquee abilities**, gained one at a time.

The level ladder

Lvl	Headline	Tier · Training bonus
1	Racial + Class Signature , starting trainings, starting spells	Apprentice · +2
2	Ability +1	
3	Perk (basic)	
4	Breadth	
5	Ability +1	
6	Perk (basic)	
7	Breadth	
8	Ability +1	Veteran · +3
9	Perk (basic)	
10	Breadth	
11	Ability +1	
12	Perk (advanced)	
13	Breadth	
14	Ability +1	
15	Perk (advanced)	Master · +4
16	Breadth	
17	Ability +1	
18	Perk (advanced)	
19	Breadth	
20	Capstone (your Class Signature ascends)	

Every level also raises HP (+1d6 + Might , roll at the table; a 1 or 2 counts as 3 — no one feels punished for leveling). **Casters' mana** rises automatically too, since the pool is level + ability .

The three headlines

- **Ability +1** (levels 2, 5, 8, 11, 14, 17 — six total). Raise one ability by +1 , **maximum +5** . This is the only headline that touches your dice math, so it's rationed.
- **Perk** (levels 3, 6, 9, 12, 15, 18 — six total). **Deepen one of your components**: unlock its next perk. Basic perks come first (3/6/9), advanced perks later (12/15/18). You choose which component to advance each time.
- **Breadth** (levels 4, 7, 10, 13, 16, 19 — six total). The roster's two halves grow in parallel:
 - **Casters** learn +1 **spell** (of a tier you can currently afford). Spells known climb **3 → 9**.
 - **Everyone else** gains +1 **training** (a new skill). Trainings climb **3 → 9** (4 → 10 for Humans).

- (*Half-casters and other gish count as casters — they take the spell.*)

The tiers

Three tiers, the spine the whole game is balanced against — training bonus, monster difficulty, and material grade all key off them:

- **Apprentice — levels 1–7:** training bonus +2 . Local stakes: a village, a forest, a single dungeon. PCs are dangerous to bandits and goblins; one hit from an ogre can drop them.
- **Veteran — levels 8–14:** training bonus +3 . Regional stakes: a duchy, a frontier, a city-state. PCs are known by name and face elite enemies and lesser magic users.
- **Master — levels 15–20:** training bonus +4 . Mythic stakes: a continent, a god, a calamity. PCs are legendary, and the monsters they fight are individually named threats.

A "Tier 1" monster is built for an Apprentice party, "Tier 2" for Veteran, "Tier 3" for Master (12-monsters.md). The GM picks the tier; the math takes care of itself.

The frozen ceiling

The training bonus stops at +4 and any single ability stops at +5 . So the highest attack or check total in the game is $d20 + 5 + 4 = d20 + 9$, against the same 10 / 15 / 20 targets — **and that ceiling is reached around the veteran tier and never rises again.**

This is deliberate. The back half of the game (levels 8–20) doesn't make your numbers bigger — it makes your **toolkit** bigger: more perks, more spells, more skills, more HP. A level-20 hero isn't *more accurate* than a level-8 one; they have more answers and can take more punishment. Bounded accuracy is preserved for the whole campaign, so monster math never unravels.

Leveling triggers

Use **milestone leveling** by default. The GM decides when the party has done enough — usually after a major scene, a completed dungeon, or a story arc closing.

A reasonable cadence:

- **Level 2** after the first real session of play.
- **Level 3** after the first proper adventure (3–5 sessions).
- From there, roughly **one level per 2–4 sessions**, faster early and slower at the master tier.

Don't track XP. Levels are punctuation in the story, not a spreadsheet. The GM may award **half-levels** for major in-between accomplishments to keep players who miss a session from falling behind.

Resting

There is **one rest type**: roughly 8 hours of safety — sleep, a watch rotation, hot food. After a rest, each character:

- Regains **all HP**.
- Regains **all mana**.

- Recovers from any condition that doesn't have a longer duration written on it.
- Refreshes "once per rest" abilities.

There is no short rest, no hit dice, no per-encounter resource. **You are either at the fight or recovering from the fight; nothing in between.**

If the party tries to rest in unsafe terrain, the GM rolls a chance of interruption — usually $2 \text{ in } 6$. If interrupted, the rest doesn't complete and resources don't refresh. **Resting between fights mid-dungeon should be hard** — it's the tension that keeps resource management interesting now that per-encounter recovery is gone.

What progression doesn't do

- **No feats.** Growth happens via perks and signatures, not a parallel feat system.
- **No multiclassing.** A class is a commitment; re flavor instead.
- **No buying trainings off-schedule.** New trainings come on breadth levels (and, rarely, as a GM story award).
- **No magic-item attunement slots.** Items work when held or worn.
- **No XP.** Milestones only.
- **No rising accuracy past the frozen ceiling.** Levels 8–20 add tools and HP, not bigger to-hit numbers.

The numbers that change on your sheet from level 1 to 20:

- **HP** (every level).
- **Training bonus** (twice: at 8 and 15).
- **Six ability bumps.**
- **Six perks** unlocked, plus the level-20 capstone.
- **Spells known** (casters) **or trainings** (everyone else), six of them.

That's the whole growth curve. A level-20 sheet is fuller than a level-1 one, but it's still a list you can read in a minute.

04 — Skills and Checks

This document is short because the system is short. There is no skill list; there are **trainings** (introduced in 02-character-creation.md) and there is the **core mechanic** (from 01-core-mechanic.md). This doc just explains how those two interact at the table.

The check, formally

When the GM calls for a check:

1. **The GM names an ability** (Might, Agility, Mind, Spirit, or Charisma) and a **target number** (10, 15, or 20).
2. **The player rolls** `d20 + ability modifier`.
3. **If the player has a relevant training**, they also add their **training bonus** (`+2` / `+3` / `+4`).
4. **Compare total to target.** Meet or beat: success. Miss: failure.

That's it. A check is one sentence: *"Roll Agility, target 15."*

The GM's job

The GM does three things when calling for a check:

1. Decide if a check is needed at all

Don't roll if:

- The character would obviously succeed (a Mage identifying a basic glyph in their own tradition).
- The character would obviously fail (the Warrior with `-1` Mind translating dead languages).
- The outcome doesn't change the story.

This is the most important GM skill. **Most "skill checks" in 5e are unnecessary.** Call rolls only at moments of pressure.

2. Pick the ability

The action the player describes determines the ability. The GM picks the one that best fits *how* the character is doing the thing.

- *"I shove the door open."* → Might.
- *"I jiggle the lock."* → Agility.
- *"I look for the keyhole's hidden mechanism."* → Mind.
- *"I sweet-talk the guard into opening it."* → Charisma.
- *"I steel myself against the dread seeping under the door."* → Spirit.

Social rolls key off Charisma by default — persuading, deceiving, intimidating, performing. **Spirit** covers willpower against the unnatural (resisting a curse's pull, holding faith); **Mind** covers reasoning and recall. When a social read is really *perception of a lie*, that's Mind or Insight, not Charisma.

If the player wants to use a different ability than the GM expected, they can argue for it. *"I'm strong, so I rip the lock out instead of picking it."* The GM may allow it, possibly with different consequences. **Player creativity should be rewarded, not arbitrated against.**

3. Pick the target number

Target	When to use
10 (Easy)	The kind of thing a competent person does most days. A trained character almost always succeeds.
15 (Hard)	Real difficulty. Failure is plausible. The default when uncertain.
20 (Heroic)	A story-worthy feat. Even the best can miss.

Edge cases: **5** for "trivial but the dice could be funny," **25** for "legendary." These should be rare. Don't invent a 12 or a 17 — you'll just slow play. **The three numbers exist on purpose.**

When trainings apply

A training applies whenever the **fiction** of what the character is doing is recognizably the thing the training names. Concrete tests:

- "I climb a sheer wall." → **Athletics** (Might/Agility), or **Acrobatics** if a tumble or balance situation, **Wilderness** if it's a cliffside the character has been raised on.
- "I lie to the guard." → **Persuasion** (smooth lie), **Insight** doesn't apply (that reads people, not deceives them), **Performance** isn't a training in this game so flavor it as Persuasion.
- "I notice the assassin in the crowd." → **Perception** (raw seeing/hearing) or **Insight** (something feels wrong about him). The player picks if they're trained in either; the GM picks if neither.

When a training *might* apply but is a stretch, the GM has two good options:

- **"Yes, but with disadvantage."** The training helps, but this isn't its core use.
- **"No, but you can use a different one if you can justify it."** Hand the creative work back to the player.

Avoid: *"That doesn't count, no bonus."* That's a flat answer and it kills the moment. **Always say yes-with-a-twist or hand it back.**

Group checks

When the whole party tries the same thing — sneaking, climbing, holding back the avalanche together — use the **weakest-link** rule from 01-core-mechanic.md:

- Everyone rolls.
- If half or more succeed, the **group** succeeds.
- Otherwise the group fails, and the GM picks one of the failed rolls to drive the complication.

This is fast at the table and avoids the "one bad roller dooms the party" problem.

Aid and helping

When one character helps another — boosting them over a wall, distracting a guard while another sneaks — the helper does **not** roll. Instead:

A character who is in a position to meaningfully help, and who is themselves competent enough to provide that help, **grants advantage** to the character making the roll.

Two helpers do not stack to "super-advantage." One source of advantage is the cap. Beyond that, the helpers are spectators.

The GM may rule that a helper isn't truly competent (the wizard "helping" the rogue pick a lock has no idea how locks work) and refuse the advantage. Be fair but not stingy.

Repeated attempts

A character who fails a check generally **cannot** simply re-roll until they succeed. The roll represents not a single attempt but the character's *current capacity to succeed at this task right now under this pressure*.

Trying again requires:

- A change in approach.
- A change in circumstances.
- New information.
- Or more time, if time isn't pressing.

If a player insists on retrying the same action the same way, the GM should narrate the failure forward — "you cannot pick this lock with this set of tools tonight" — not invite a new roll.

The exception: in a calm moment, a character may take a long time on a task with no opposition, and **automatically succeed at Easy and Hard targets** if their modifier could meet the target on a **10** (a "take 10" rule). They cannot take 10 on Heroic targets.

Knowing things

A note on lore and recall.

Don't roll to "know" something most characters in the world would know. The Warrior knows what a knight looks like. The Priest knows the major gods. The Mage knows that the academy in the capital teaches evocation.

Roll only when the knowledge would distinguish a trained expert from a layperson. Recognizing a *specific* heraldry, identifying *what* god a cult worships from a specific symbol, recalling the *correct* incantation to dispel a particular ward — those are Lore/Religion/Arcana rolls.

A common GM mistake: gating obvious information behind rolls. Don't do this. If the player describes their character looking at the runes on the door, and recognizing those runes is the whole point of the next scene, **just give them the answer**. The roll is for moments of doubt, not for permission to engage with the world.

Failing forward

When a check fails, the GM has three options for what failure means:

1. **You don't get what you want.** The lock doesn't open. The lie isn't believed.
2. **You get it, but at a cost.** You climb the cliff, but the rope frays — next climber rolls at disadvantage. You convince the guard, but he wants a favor in return.
3. **Something worse happens.** You drop your tools down the well. The guard recognizes you from a wanted poster.

Mix these. **A campaign of "you don't get what you want"** is a campaign of stalled scenes. Failing forward keeps the story moving even when the dice are cold.

Worked examples

- *"I want to climb the keep wall in the rain."* GM: Might, Hard (15). Trained in Athletics? Add bonus. Rope from the Scout? Advantage.
- *"I want to convince the captain to let us through."* GM: Charisma, Hard (15). Trained in Persuasion? Yes. Captain knows the party's reputation? Advantage. Party has no documentation? Disadvantage. Cancels. Roll plain.
- *"I want to remember what I know about the bone-witch."* GM: nothing rolls — the Mage has Lore and just *knows* the bone-witch was banished from the academy two centuries ago. *"But what does she want now?"* That's a roll: Mind, Hard. Trained in Arcana? Add bonus.
- *"I want to leap from the chandelier and stab the guard."* GM: this is two things. Agility check to land it (Hard, 15); the stab is a normal attack roll on success. On a natural 1 climbing, you fall and take damage. On a natural 20 on the attack, the guard is dead and the room watches in stunned silence.

What this doc deliberately omits

- A list of "DCs by task type." (Three numbers; the GM picks.)
- A breakdown of *every* training and what rolls it covers. (The fiction tells you.)
- Skill challenge mechanics. (Group checks and failing forward cover it.)
- Tool proficiencies. (Folded into trainings — Crafting covers tools.)
- Passive perception/investigation/insight scores. (The GM either tells the players what they notice, or asks them to roll. There is no third middle state.)

If the rule isn't here, the answer is *the GM picks an ability, picks a target, and you roll*. That's the whole system.

05 — Combat

Combat is the most rules-dense moment in a tabletop RPG, and it's where 5e bloats the worst. We collapse the action economy hard.

The turn

A creature's turn is two things:

1. **Move**, up to your **Speed** (default 6 squares / 30 feet for most characters).
2. **Act** — one action.

That's it. No bonus action. No reaction by default. You may **split your move** around your action: move 3 squares, attack, move 3 more. You may also skip the move, or skip the action.

Common actions:

- **Attack**. Make one weapon attack against a target in range. (See 06-attack-and-defense.md.)
- **Cast a spell**. Choose a known spell, pay its mana cost, resolve. (See 09-magic.md.)
- **Dash**. Move your speed again. (Total this turn: up to twice your speed.)
- **Hide**. Roll Agility (Stealth if trained) vs. the highest enemy Mind defense in line of sight. On success, you have advantage on your next attack and enemies have disadvantage attacking you until you reveal yourself.
- **Help**. Grant an ally advantage on their next roll, if you're in a position to plausibly help.
- **Disengage**. Move without provoking the optional Opportunity Strike (below).
- **Ready**. Choose an action and a trigger ("*if the goblin steps into the doorway, I shoot it*"). When the trigger happens, the action resolves immediately. You give up your normal turn this round.
- **Use an item**. Drink a potion, throw an alchemical flask, draw a magical token.
- **Improvise**. Anything else. The GM adjudicates.

The whole table fits in your head after one fight. **That's the design target.**

What an "action" is *not*

You do not get a free bonus action, a free reaction, a free quick attack, a free off-hand swing. Two-weapon fighting is one attack with the weapon you choose. Drawing a weapon is free (folded into the same turn as using it). Talking is free.

Principle from 00-design-philosophy.md: *One rule, not three.* Veterans of 5e will keep asking "can I also...?" The answer is almost always no, and they will adapt within one session.

Initiative

Use **side initiative**. The whole party rolls together against the whole enemy side.

1. One representative per side rolls **d20 + their Agility**.
2. The higher total goes first.

3. **Within a side, players choose the order** of their turns each round. (For the enemy side, the GM does the same.)
4. The next round, roll again. Initiative is not fixed across rounds.

Why this works:

- One roll, not seven.
- Lets players coordinate ("I'll attack first, you finish him").
- Means the GM doesn't have to track a turn order list.
- A losing initiative this round can be a winning one the next.

Ties: players win ties.

Surprise: if one side ambushes the other, the ambushing side automatically goes first this round (no initiative roll). Roll initiative normally from round two.

Movement

Movement is measured in **squares** (a square is 5 feet of fictional space). A default creature has Speed **6**.

Movement rules:

- **Diagonal movement** counts as one square. Don't count **1.5**.
- **Difficult terrain** (rubble, dense forest, knee-deep water): each square costs **2**.
- **Climbing** or **swimming**: half speed, unless you have a climb/swim mode.
- **Standing up from prone**: costs half your speed.
- **Jumping**: you can long-jump a number of squares equal to your Might (minimum 1), and high-jump half that, with a running start. Without a running start, half each. No roll needed unless it's a stretch — then Athletics check, Hard.

You can't end your turn sharing a square with another creature unless it's friendly and willing. You can pass through allies freely; through enemies only by Disengaging or with class features that allow it.

Set to Strike (heavy gear)

Heavy gear is built for planting, not chasing. On a turn where you **both move and attack**:

- wielding a **heavy weapon** *or* wearing **heavy armor** → that **attack is at disadvantage**;
- wielding a heavy weapon *and* wearing heavy armor → you **can't do both — take your move *or* your attack this turn, not both**.

Stand your ground (use no movement) and you attack normally. (*Disadvantage is binary, so the "both heavy" case escalates to denial rather than stacking dice.*) This is the cost that makes heavy gear an *immovable anchor* instead of a free upgrade — no Speed penalty needed. Light and medium weapons in light or no armor move and strike freely. See 19-classes.md; heavy armor also bars ranged weapons entirely.

By default, you can move freely around the battlefield. **Opportunity strikes are off** unless one of the following applies:

- A monster has the **Sentinel** trait. (Bears, dragons, and a few elites do.)
- A spell, effect, or class feature explicitly enables it.

When opportunity strikes are on for a creature: if an enemy leaves a square adjacent to that creature without Disengaging, the creature may make **one attack** against them as they leave. This does not cost the creature a turn — it's a free interrupt, used at most once per round.

Why this is optional by default: the 5e "opportunity attack everywhere" rule makes every movement a math problem. We default-off and let specific creatures bring it on for tactical color.

Reactions

There is **no general reaction slot**. A character with a feature or spell that says "*as a reaction...*" can use it according to that feature's rules. Otherwise, the only off-turn thing a character can do is *speak*.

The Mage's **Shield** spell (see 10-spell-list.md) is the most common example: it specifies it can be cast as a reaction to an incoming attack.

Off-turn interrupts are deliberately rare. **The action is on the turning player.** A new player should never be confused about whether they "can do something" while another player is acting — the answer is almost always no.

Cover

Three states only:

- **No cover.** Normal attacks.
- **Half cover** (low wall, corner of doorway, ally in the way): attacks against the target have **disadvantage**.
- **Full cover.** The target cannot be targeted directly. Area effects (a Fireball thrown over the wall) still apply.

The "+2/+5 cover" math of 5e is replaced by "either it matters or it doesn't, and when it matters, it's disadvantage."

Flanking

Two allies on opposite sides of an enemy: that enemy is **flanked**. Attacks against a flanked enemy from either flanking ally have **advantage**.

This is the simplest tactical lever in the game. Most fights will be partly about creating flanks.

Range

Two states:

- **Close** — adjacent, melee range. (1 square, generally.)
- **Far** — anywhere else within line of sight.

Weapons specify whether they reach far. Bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, and spells generally have a far range (with limits given in the spell or weapon entry). Melee weapons don't.

Some weapons (longbows, ranged spells) have a maximum range; beyond it, attacks are at disadvantage or impossible. The weapon entry tells you. **There is no "long range" vs. "short range" math.** You're in range or you're not, possibly with disadvantage.

Surprise and stealth

If one or more party members are hidden when combat starts, **they get a free attack at advantage** before initiative is rolled. After that, normal rounds begin.

If the whole party is hidden and they attack a surprised enemy, **the enemy side skips its first round** entirely.

A round in practice

Four PCs vs. three goblins. Side init: party rolls 14, goblins roll 17. Goblins go.

Goblin side, round 1:

- *Goblin Archer* moves behind cover (half cover) and shoots Brenna the Scout: disadvantage from cover, miss.
- *Goblin Brute* charges the Warrior and attacks: hit, 5 damage.
- *Goblin Sneak* tries to flank the Mage: moves around behind, attacks: hit, 4 damage.

Player side, round 1:

- *Warrior* attacks Goblin Brute, hits, drops it to 0 → Cleave triggers → free attack on Goblin Sneak, hits, kills it. (One action, two dead goblins.)
- *Scout* moves, shoots Goblin Archer, hits with advantage (flanked by Warrior's positioning), Sneak Strike damage applies.
- *Mage* casts Magic Missile at the Archer, no roll, autohit.
- *Priest* moves to the Warrior, uses Divine Touch to heal $1d6 + \text{Spirit}$.

Round one took five minutes. **That is the pace we are building for.**

What combat doesn't have

- Action economy with three slots.
- Opportunity attacks as a default rule.
- A "concentration save" mini-game.
- Hit dice spending mid-combat.
- A separate initiative count for each creature.
- Reactions as a slot most creatures have but rarely use.
- Tracking "free actions" vs. "actions on your turn."
- Movement type math (e.g., "every 5 feet of difficult terrain costs +1 hex of movement").
- Tracking "rounds since you last used X."

If a 5e-trained player asks about any of the above, the answer is *that's not how this game does it*. Then continue play.

06 — Attack and Defense

This is the most-used subsystem in the game. It's the core mechanic from 01-core-mechanic.md with combat-specific labels attached.

The attack roll

Roll d20, add your attack ability modifier and (if trained) your training bonus, compare to the target's defense. Meet or beat: hit. Miss: miss.

That's it. Every attack in the game is the same shape.

What goes into "attack ability"

Every attack you make — weapon *or* spell — uses your class's one primary ability. That single stat (Might, Agility, Mind, Spirit, or Charisma) is what *powers* your character: you add it to every attack roll **and** to your damage.

- A **Might** class swings, throws, and shoots with Might.
- An **Agility** class does all of it with Agility.
- A **Mind, Spirit, or Charisma** caster makes spell attacks *and* weapon attacks with that pool — magic and blade run off the same stat.

There's no per-weapon ability and no separate "weapon proficiency": the weapon's *class* sets its damage die, hands, and range (17-weapons.md); your *primary* sets the attack and damage bonus; and if your class is **trained** in that weapon (or in casting), add your training bonus to the hit.

Defenses are unchanged — the single-primary rule is about *offense*, not protection. Armor is still $10 + \text{Agility}$ (or $10 + \text{Might}$ in heavy armor) + material; $\text{Mind} = 10 + \text{Mind}$; $\text{Spirit} = 10 + \text{Spirit}$; $\text{Charisma} = 10 + \text{Charisma}$.

Defenses

Every creature has four defenses. They are static numbers.

Armor

The number an attacker rolls against for physical hits — sword swings, arrows, claws.

$\text{Armor} = 10 + \text{Agility} + \text{worn armor bonus}$

If you wear **heavy armor**, Armor uses Might instead of Agility:

$\text{Armor} = 10 + \text{Might} + \text{heavy armor bonus}$

Your armor's **material** sets the bonus — light (leather/hide) is Agility-based, heavy (metal/stone) is Might-based. See 18-armor.md.

Typical level 1 Armor values:

- Unarmored Mage with +1 Agility: **11**.
- Leather (light) Scout with +5 Agility: **17**.
- Steel-armored (heavy) Warrior with +3 Might: **17**.

Mind

The number an attacker rolls against for effects that attack the target's **senses and intellect** — illusion, sleep, psychic assault, mind-reading, paralysis, outright domination.

Mind defense = 10 + Mind

Spirit

The number an attacker rolls against for effects that attack the target's **soul and life-force** — possession, banishment, death magic, soul-burn, divine/unholy wrath.

Spirit defense = 10 + Spirit

Charisma

The number an attacker rolls against for effects that attack the target's **composure and will to act** — charm, fear, magical command, taunts, crushing despair. Resisting these is force of personality, not intellect or soul.

Charisma defense = 10 + Charisma

Which defense gets attacked?

The weapon, spell, or attack tells you. As a rule:

- **Sword, claw, arrow, fist, fall damage:** Armor.
- **Sleep, illusion, psychic, paralysis, mind-control:** Mind.
- **Charm, fear, command, taunt:** Charisma.
- **Banishment, soul-burn, death-magic, holy/unholy wrath:** Spirit.
- **Fire, cold, lightning, poison from an area effect** that the target should be able to dodge or shrug off: **Armor** (because the target's reflexes and toughness are protecting them). Most "elemental" attacks target Armor.
- **Fire, cold, lightning, poison that ignores the body** (e.g., a curse that boils blood without a chance to dodge): **Spirit**.

The line between Mind and Charisma: Mind effects *hijack cognition* — they fool the senses or seize the brain (you can't tell the illusion is fake; your body locks up). Charisma effects *bend the heart* — they make you feel friendship, terror, or obedience you'd never choose. If the magic overrides what you *perceive or think*, it's Mind; if it overrides what you *feel or will*, it's Charisma.

The spell description tells you. If it doesn't, default to Armor.

Damage

After a hit, roll damage:

Damage = weapon die + material bonus + attack ability modifier

The **material bonus** is the flat damage your weapon adds for what it's forged from (**+0** Iron up to **+5** Daedric — see 17-weapons.md). **Spells** use spell die + ability and have no material bonus.

You do **not** add the training bonus to damage. Training affects the *hit*, not the *severity*. Material affects the *severity*, never the *hit*.

Damage dice for the most common weapons:

Weapon	Damage
Dagger, club, sling	1d4
Shortsword, mace, hand axe, light crossbow, shortbow	1d6
Longsword, warhammer, longbow, heavy crossbow	1d8
Greatsword, greataxe, polearm, maul	1d10

These are the **class** dice. Every weapon then adds its **material bonus** flat on top (**+0** – **+5**); a Steel longsword is 1d8 + 1 + ability . See 17-weapons.md for the full ladder.

Spells specify their own damage dice; see 10-spell-list.md.

Minimum damage on a hit is 1. A **+0** mod on a 1d4 rolling a 1 still does 1 damage. Nothing scary about a hit is wasted.

Critical hits

A **natural 20** on the attack roll is a critical hit. Roll the damage dice **twice** and add them together; **modifiers are added once**, not twice.

Example: Scout with Agility **+3** hits with a shortbow, natural 20. Damage is 1d6 + 1d6 + 3 . If both d6s roll high, that's a big hit.

Critical hits don't otherwise have effects. No critical confirmation roll. No "spinal injury" tables. Just doubled dice.

Critical fumbles

A **natural 1** on the attack roll: you miss, and a complication happens. The GM picks something appropriate from this menu:

- You drop your weapon (it's at your feet; pick it up costs your move next turn).
- You hit an ally next to your target (roll damage at half, against the ally).
- You stumble (you're prone).
- You expose a flank (the next attack on you this round has advantage).
- You break your bowstring / your crossbow misfires / your spell sputters (you can't use this weapon/spell again until you spend an action to recover it).

The GM picks one each time; don't roll on a table. The complication should fit the fiction. A wizard who fumbles a spell shouldn't drop their sword; they should miscast.

Spell attacks vs. spell effects

Spells come in two shapes:

1. **Spell attack.** A spell that the caster rolls to hit with — *Fire Bolt*, *Eldritch Blast*, etc. Use the standard attack procedure: $d20 + \text{spell ability} + \text{training}$ vs. the target's defense.
2. **Spell save.** *In this game, there is no save.* A spell that in 5e calls for the target to save is rewritten so the **caster rolls to hit** against the relevant defense. *Fireball* is the caster rolling vs. each target's Armor (or Spirit, or whatever the spell says). On a hit, full damage; on a miss, half damage (or none, per the spell).

Same procedure as a melee attack. The only difference is which ability and which defense.

Range

- **Melee:** the target must be adjacent (1 square away). Polearms reach 2 squares.
- **Ranged weapon:** the weapon entry gives a range. Beyond it, attack is at disadvantage; double that range and you can't attack at all.
- **Spells:** the spell entry gives the range.

Don't track range in feet during the fight. Squares are enough. Bows reach across the room; crossbows the same; thrown weapons about 5 squares; daggers thrown about 4.

Two-weapon fighting

Still **one attack per turn** — there's no bonus off-hand swing. Wielding **two light weapons** (both hands, no shield) steps your damage die **up one size** ($1d4 \rightarrow 1d6$, $1d6 \rightarrow 1d8$): the off-hand blade folds into a single, harder hit, not a second roll. See 17-weapons.md. Wielding two non-light weapons is pure flavor — use the larger die.

Unarmed attacks

$1d4 + \text{Might}$ damage. Anyone can do this. Some monsters do much more.

Improvised weapons

Anything you can pick up: $1d4$, with Might. The chair, the bottle, the chandelier. The GM may rule it does $1d6$ if it's clearly a big improvised weapon, or $1d10$ if it's a falling chandelier on someone's head.

Multiple attacks

Most characters get **one attack per turn**. Warriors with the **Cleave** feature (see 02-character-creation.md) may make a second attack only when their first reduces a target to 0 HP. There is no "Extra Attack at level 5" feature in this game; multiple attacks are class-feature unlocks, not a default expansion.

A Mage who casts a spell that includes multiple targets (Magic Missile, Burning Hands) is making **one action that affects multiple creatures**, not multiple attacks. Resolve each target separately if the spell needs an attack roll.

Damage types

The game uses damage types loosely:

- **Physical** (slashing, piercing, bludgeoning — we don't distinguish).
- **Fire, cold, lightning, acid, poison, thunder.**
- **Necrotic** (death magic, soul-burn).
- **Radiant** (holy, sun, healing reversed).
- **Psychic** (mental, dream).

Damage type matters only when a monster, item, or condition cares. Some undead are *immune* to poison. Some elementals are *vulnerable* (take double) to specific damage types. The monster's stat block tells you. If it doesn't, all damage is just damage.

We don't track resistances on every monster. Most fights, every weapon does its full damage. Resistances are flavor for specific encounters.

A worked attack

A Knight (Might primary) swings a greatsword at the Orc Captain.

- Knight: Might +3, trained in heavy weapons (+2 at the Apprentice tier), **Steel** greatsword (1d10, material +1).
- Orc Captain Armor: 15.
- Roll: $d20 + 3$ (Might) + 2 (training) = $d20 + 5$ vs. 15. (*Material never touches this roll.*)
- Result on d20: 12. Total 17. Hit.
- Damage: $1d10 + 1$ (material) + 3 (Might). Roll d10: 7. Damage: 11.
- The Orc Captain takes 11.

If the d20 had shown 20: damage is $1d10 + 1d10 + 1 + 3$ (dice doubled, flat mods once), critical. Say $7 + 9 + 1 + 3 = 20$ damage.

If the d20 had shown 1: complication. GM says: "*You overswing; you're prone.*"

Total time at the table: under 10 seconds.

What attack/defense doesn't have

- Saving throws.
- AC + touch AC + flat-footed AC.
- Damage reduction (replaced by resistance/immunity).
- A separate weapon attack bonus and weapon damage bonus stat.
- Spell save DCs separate from attack bonuses.
- Cleaving, sweeping, called shots, sundering, disarming as separate sub-systems. (Improvise via the d20 + ruling.)

- Critical hit confirmation rolls.
- Variable critical thresholds (no 19–20 crit weapons).
- Power attack, expertise, or other "trade-bonus-for-bonus" knob-twisting.

When a 5e player asks about any of those: not in this game. Roll the d20.

07 — HP, Damage, and Death

The shortest doc in the rules. HP is the only health system in the game.

HP

A character's hit points represent everything between *standing and fighting* and *down and bleeding*. We don't separate "luck points" from "real wounds." It's all HP.

Starting HP is set by your **armor tier** (19-classes.md):

- Heavy armor: $10 + \text{Might}$
- Light armor: $8 + \text{Might}$
- No armor: $6 + \text{Might}$

Per-level HP gain is $1d6 + \text{Might}$, rolled at the table when you level. A roll of 1 or 2 becomes a 3. No one feels punished by leveling.

By level 10 a heavy-armor fighter has roughly 80 HP and a naked caster roughly 50; by level 20 those climb to roughly 175 and 110. HP grows every level for the whole campaign, so monsters scale their damage (not their to-hit) to keep pace — see the within-tier scaling note in 12-monsters.md.

Taking damage

When you take damage, subtract it from your current HP. No tracking damage types separately. No accumulating "wound levels."

If a damage source applies a **condition** (poisoned, burning, etc.), apply that too. See 08-conditions.md.

Healing

Three ways to heal:

1. **A rest** (one full rest = full HP and mana). See 03-progression.md.
2. **A spell**. Priests' *Divine Touch* and *Cure Wounds*; certain other spells. See 10-spell-list.md.
3. **A potion**. Healing potions restore $1d8 + 2$ HP. Drinking a potion is an action.

A character at full HP cannot be over-healed. Excess healing is wasted.

No "natural healing" between fights without a full rest. If the party wants to recover after a fight, they need a safe place and 8 hours.

Going down

When a character's HP reaches 0, they don't die immediately. They go down:

- They are **unconscious** and **prone**.
- They can't take actions, move, or speak.
- They drop whatever they're holding.

A downed character will **die** at the end of the next round of combat if not stabilized. Until then, they hover.

Stabilizing

To stabilize a downed ally, an adjacent ally spends their **action** on one of:

- **First aid.** A Medicine training check, Hard (15). On success, the downed character is stable — still unconscious, but not dying. They will wake naturally after 10 minutes or instantly if healed for any amount of HP.
- **Healing magic.** Any healing spell or potion: the downed character returns to consciousness at the healed HP value. If the heal would bring them to 0 or below, they remain down.

A character who is stabilized but still at 0 HP can be picked up and carried. They're out of the fight, but they're not dying.

Dying and dead

A character who reaches the end of the round at 0 HP and has not been stabilized **dies**.

"End of the round" means: after every creature has taken its turn in the current round. So if you go down on your own turn, your party has the rest of the round to save you. If you go down on an enemy turn, your allies get their turns this round to act.

This is the **only death rule**. No death saving throws. No "you lose three saves and die." A downed PC will die unless someone helps them, and they have one round to be helped.

The grim version of this rule is: **a downed PC who is hit again while down dies instantly**. A monster that wants to make sure stoops and kills. This is the default; a softer table can disable it.

Massive damage

If a single attack would do damage equal to or greater than the character's **maximum HP**, they die outright. No saving them. This is for catastrophic single hits — a dragon's bite at full force, a fall from 200 feet. It's rare. It's also fair, because the same rule applies to enemies — and players will exploit it gleefully when they figure out the math.

Coming back

If a character dies, they are dead. There is no automatic resurrection. Three options exist for bringing the dead back:

1. **A Resurrection spell** (high-tier, costs 5 mana, see 10-spell-list.md). Returns the character at 1 HP if their body is intact. Costs the caster a permanent point of Spirit until their next level — death magic has a tax.
2. **A divine bargain.** The GM may rule that a god, demon, or ancestral spirit can be petitioned. There is always a price. This is a story event, not a rule.
3. **The player makes a new character.** The default option. If the campaign continues, a new character should be ready to introduce in the next session.

This game treats death as meaningful. It is rare for it to happen at the apprentice tier (party can usually rally), more common at the veteran tier (monsters bite harder), and a real risk at the master tier (the stakes are mythic).

Healing the party between fights

Once combat ends, characters with HP above 0 are *fine* — they aren't bleeding in the narrative sense, they just have less buffer for the next fight. The Priest's Divine Touch is the main mid-adventure healing tool; potions are the next. A full rest is the only way to top off without resources.

A common pattern: the party finishes a fight, the Priest spends a Divine Touch on the worst-wounded Warrior, everyone agrees they have enough HP to push on, and they keep moving.

Damage examples

- The Scout has 12 HP. An orc hits for 5. The Scout is at 7.
- A goblin throws a flask of burning oil; Scout fails to dodge, takes 4 damage and is **burning** (1d6 per turn until put out). Scout is at 3 HP.
- Scout spends an action putting themselves out. They are at 3 HP, no longer burning.
- The orc captain attacks: 6 damage. Scout drops to **-3**. Treat as 0; Scout is down.
- The Warrior is adjacent. Warrior's turn: uses Divine Touch... wait, the Warrior doesn't have that. The Priest is across the room. Warrior chooses to drag Scout behind cover (a move) and use their action to apply first aid: Medicine training check, Hard. Roll: 16, success. Scout is stable but still at 0.
- Next round, the Priest moves over, uses Divine Touch: heals $1d6 + 3 = 5$. Scout wakes up at 5 HP.

What this doc doesn't include

- Death saving throws.
- Hit dice as a resource.
- Lingering injuries.
- Temporary HP.
- Wound thresholds, bloodied states, or staggered conditions.
- HP recovery during a short rest. (There is no short rest.)
- Concentration on healing.
- A "stabilized but bleeding" timer in seconds.
- A complete table of resurrection costs.

If a player or GM wants any of those, the question is *what dramatic moment does this enable?* — and if there's a good answer, the GM rules it once for this campaign and the rule sticks.

08 — Conditions

Conditions are the only status effects in the game. There are **ten**. Each is one sentence of mechanical text plus a short clearing rule. **You can have multiple conditions at once**, but each is independent — they don't combine into new rules.

The list

Blinded

You cannot see. Your attacks are at **disadvantage**, and attacks against you are at **advantage**. *Clears when the cause ends.*

Burning

At the start of your turn, take **1d6 fire damage**. *Clears when you spend an action to put yourself out, are submerged in water, or are healed by magic.*

Charmed

The source of the charm has **advantage** on social rolls against you, and you cannot willingly attack the source. *Clears when the source attacks you, when the charm's duration ends, or on the GM's call after a dramatic moment.*

Frightened

You cannot move closer to the source of the fear, and your attacks against the source are at **disadvantage**. *Clears when the source is out of sight, when the fear's duration ends, or when an ally helps you steady yourself (action).*

Grappled

Your speed is **0** and you cannot move yourself. *Clears when you spend an action to break free (Might check, Hard) or when the grappler releases you.*

Poisoned

Your attacks and ability checks are at **disadvantage**. *Clears at the start of your turn on a successful Spirit check (Hard, 15), or via magical cure, or when the duration ends.*

Prone

You are on the ground. Your attacks are at **disadvantage**. Attacks against you are at **advantage** if the attacker is adjacent, and at **disadvantage** if the attacker is far away (you're a smaller target). Standing up costs half your speed. *Clears when you stand.*

Restrained

Your speed is **0**, your attacks are at **disadvantage**, and attacks against you are at **advantage**. *Clears as appropriate to the cause — webs require an action to tear free, ropes need to be cut, ice melts.*

Stunned

You skip your turn entirely. No move, no action. Attacks against you are at **advantage**. *Clears at the end of your skipped turn unless the source says otherwise.*

Exhausted

All your rolls — attacks, checks, defenses — use **disadvantage**, OR enemies have advantage if you'd already have disadvantage on the action. *Clears with a full rest.*

How conditions are applied

A condition is applied by:

- A successful attack that says so (a spider bite that poisons).
- A successful spell (a hold spell that paralyzes).
- An environmental hazard (a pit of green slime).
- A class feature.
- The GM's discretion in narrative situations (a character who walks through a noxious cloud is **poisoned** until they breathe clean air).

A condition is **not** applied randomly — there's always a fictional cause.

How conditions stack (or don't)

You can have **any number of conditions at once**, but **the same condition does not stack**. Being poisoned twice is just being poisoned. The duration is the longer of the two sources.

When two conditions impose disadvantage on the same roll, you still have disadvantage (not "double disadvantage" — there's no such thing). Disadvantage is binary.

Likewise, one source of advantage cancels with one source of disadvantage. (See 01-core-mechanic.md.)

The Downed state

A character at 0 HP is not "conditioned" in the same way — they are **downed**, which is its own state from 07-hp-damage-death.md. For mechanical purposes, treat a downed character as **Prone**, **Stunned**, and **Blinded**. But the rule that matters is the death timer, not the conditions.

What conditions don't include

We deliberately do not have:

- **Petrified**. If a creature turns to stone, that's just *death*. (A high-magic GM can rule it differently for story.)
- **Deafened**. No one ever interestingly suffers from this mechanically. If the GM wants it, they impose disadvantage on hearing-based checks and call it a day.
- **Incapacitated**. Replaced by *Stunned* or *Downed* depending on cause.
- **Paralyzed**. Replaced by *Stunned* + *Prone*. (Apply both.)

- **Unconscious.** Replaced by *Downed*, or by *Sleeping* (which is just narrative; combat wakes you).
- **Exhaustion levels 1–6.** Just *Exhausted* — one level, binary.
- **Invisible.** Not a tracked condition. The GM gives the hidden creature advantage on attacks and imposes disadvantage on attacks against them; this is handled by *Hide*, *cover*, and *advantage* rules, not as a separate status.

If a 5e player asks about one of these, point to its replacement.

Conditions on monsters

Conditions apply to monsters the same way they apply to PCs. A *Frightened* dragon has disadvantage on attacks against its source of fear. A *Poisoned* ogre has disadvantage on all rolls. **Symmetry holds.**

This makes player abilities that impose conditions extremely valuable — and it makes the GM cautious about handing out frightening or stunning abilities to monsters in the same encounter that the party will want to use those abilities back. Either side can lock the other down.

Tracking conditions at the table

A token, a sticky note, or just memory. Don't write a spreadsheet. The condition is one sentence; the player or GM can keep it in their head, especially because most conditions clear within a round or two.

A small helpful practice: when you apply a condition, **say what clears it** at the same moment. "*You're poisoned. Roll Spirit at the start of your turn to shake it off.*" Now the affected player knows what to do without looking it up.

09 — Magic

Magic is the biggest source of rule-bloat in D&D. We do not let it bloat here. Many classes cast (19-classes.md); all of them share one resource (**mana**), one of three **pools** (Mind, Spirit, or Charisma), and one casting mechanic that is the same as every other action in the game.

The mana pool

Every casting class has a **mana pool**, fueled by one ability — its **pool**, set by the class:

- **Mind pool:** level + Mind mana per rest. (*Studied, arcane magic.*)
- **Spirit pool:** level + Spirit mana per rest. (*Devoted, divine/primal magic.*)
- **Charisma pool:** level + Charisma mana per rest. (*Innate magic — sorcery, pact, song.*)

The three pools are mechanically identical; they differ only in *which ability* fuels and aims the magic, and so in which **defense** the caster naturally has high. The pool is just *fuel and aim* — **spells themselves are tagged by school, not by ability** (10-spell-list.md). A Mind-caster, a Spirit-caster, and a Charisma-caster can all cast the very same spell, each from their own pool. That's the only spell resource in the game. There are no 1st-level slots, 2nd-level slots, 3rd-level slots. There is no upcasting. There are no ritual slots. A spell costs N mana; you pay N mana; you cast the spell.

A typical level 1 Mage with Mind +3 has 4 mana. A level 8 Priest with Spirit +4 has 12. By level 20 a top-tier caster has ~`25` mana — a deep well, enough for several big spells per rest or a long flurry of small ones. Mana grows steadily, but **spells known cap at 9** and **the adventuring day is long** (3–5 fights between rests), so that well is spent across many encounters, not dumped into one.

Mana refreshes **only on a full rest**. There is no per-encounter recovery, no draining mana from objects, no scrolls that refund mana.

Cantrips

Cantrips cost 0 mana and can be cast as often as the caster wants. They are the caster's "weapon attack" equivalent — when out of mana, you cast cantrips.

Cantrips do not scale with character level. A cantrip's damage is what the spell entry says, period. (This is the cut from 00-design-philosophy.md: cantrips don't have damage tables that grow at levels 5/11/17.)

Principle — cantrips debuff, they don't deny. Because a cantrip is free and repeatable, it may deal its damage line and impose at most a one-round, *disadvantage-grade* rider (a slow, a fumble on the target's next turn, a single attack set up against them). A cantrip may **never** take a creature's turn away (Stunned, Restrained, Downed) or grant blanket advantage to every attacker. Turn-denial and standing advantage are *paid* effects — Lesser tier and up (see *Hold Person*, *Bless*). If a cantrip would out-perform a 1- or 3-mana spell, it's mis-tiered.

Each caster knows **2 cantrips** at character creation, free, on top of their starting spells.

Spell tiers

Spells come in four tiers by cost:

Tier	Cost	Power
Cantrip	0 mana	At-will utility, light damage, simple effects.
Lesser	1 mana	Reliable combat or utility magic. <i>Shield, Cure Wounds, Sleep</i> .
Greater	3 mana	Big effects. <i>Fireball, Hold Person, Fly</i> .
Master	5 mana	Story-shaping. <i>Resurrection, Disintegrate, Wall of Force</i> .

A caster at level 1 has only a handful of mana — enough to lean on cantrips and Lesser spells, with maybe a single Greater spell in reserve. Master spells (5 mana) are simply out of reach until the pool deepens over several levels. Tier gates *casting*, not *knowing* (below).

Tier doesn't gate what spells you *know* — only what you can *cast*. A clever level 4 Priest who somehow learned *Resurrection* still can't cast it until they have 5 mana available.

Spells known

You **know** a small list of spells; you cast from this list.

Spells known grow on your **breadth levels** (4, 7, 10, 13, 16, 19) — the same beats on which a non-caster gains a new training (03-progression.md).

Levels	Spells known
1–3	3 (starting)
4–6	4
7–9	5
10–12	6
13–15	7
16–18	8
19–20	9

Plus your 2 cantrips, picked at level 1 and never gained again. (You can swap one cantrip for another at each tier boundary — levels 8 and 15.)

When you pick a new spell at level-up, **it must be a tier you can currently afford**. You cannot pre-learn a Master spell at level 2.

At any level-up, you may swap **one spell you know for another** of the same or lower tier. Mages reread their grimoires; Priests revise their prayers.

Casting a spell

Choose a spell you know. Pay its mana cost. Roll if the spell needs a roll. Resolve.

That is the entire procedure. The "roll if the spell needs a roll" piece is the only piece with variety — see below.

Armor & casting. You cast freely in **light or no armor**. **Heavy armor blocks all spellcasting** (see 18-armor.md).

Spell attack rolls

Some spells require an attack roll. The caster rolls `d20 + pool + training` — every casting class is **trained in casting**, so the training bonus always applies — vs. the target's relevant defense (Armor, Mind, Spirit, or Charisma). On a hit, the spell does what it says.

Spell attack rolls follow the same rules as weapon attacks (see 06-attack-and-defense.md): natural 20 is a critical (doubled dice on damage spells), natural 1 is a fumble (the spell sputters — the mana is spent and a complication occurs).

Auto-hit spells

Some spells don't roll. **Magic Missile** is the classic — it hits, period, dealing fixed damage. Buffs, summons, and most utility spells are auto-hit: the caster pays mana, the spell happens.

Area spells

A few spells target an area (Fireball's blast, Burning Hands' cone). For each creature in the area, the caster rolls a single attack vs. each creature's relevant defense. **The caster rolls once per target** — yes, this is up to five or six rolls for a big fireball. It's still faster than 5e's "everyone roll a save."

Why the caster rolls instead of the targets: see 01-core-mechanic.md, the active-player-rolls principle. It keeps the active turn moving fast and avoids stopping to ask seven creatures to roll dice.

Save-or-suck spells

Spells like *Hold Person* or *Sleep* — in 5e these have a "save" mechanic. Here, the caster rolls `d20 + pool + training` vs. the target's Mind, Spirit, or Charisma defense (whichever the spell names). On a hit, the effect applies as written. On a miss, it doesn't, and the mana is still spent (you paid for the attempt, not the result).

Range, targets, components

- **Range** is specified in the spell entry. Most combat spells have a "far" range (anywhere in the current scene).
- **Targets** are specified: "one creature," "all creatures in a 4-square cone," "a willing creature you touch."
- **Components.** Not tracked. If a spell needs a verbal element, you have to be able to speak; if somatic, you have to have a free hand; if material, it's assumed you have whatever you need. Exception: a few high-tier

spells call for a rare, specific material (a diamond, a holy relic) — and the spell entry tells you that explicitly. Otherwise, no.

Concentration

Replaced by a simpler rule: **a caster can have at most one ongoing spell active at a time.**

When you cast a new ongoing spell, any previous ongoing spell ends. An "ongoing spell" is one that lasts more than one round and that affects something — *Fly*, *Hold Person*, *Bless*, *Sanctuary*, etc. The spell entry tells you it's ongoing. Single-action spells (*Fireball*, *Cure Wounds*, *Magic Missile*) are not ongoing.

A **tethered summon counts as your one ongoing spell** (see the Summoning rules in 10-spell-list.md) — so you can't run a summon *and* another ongoing spell, and you can't field two summons. This is the lever that keeps Conjuration from flooding combat with extra bodies.

If the caster goes **Downed** (HP 0), all their ongoing spells end immediately (summons vanish).

If the caster takes damage **while concentrating** — there is no concentration check. The spell continues unless they go down. **This is a deliberate simplification.** No mid-fight save-or-lose-your-spell roll.

Dispelling and counterspelling

- Most ongoing spells can be dispelled by the **Dispel Magic** spell (Greater, 3 mana). Caster rolls vs. the higher of 15 or $10 + \text{target spell's tier} \times 5$ (so dispelling a Master spell is Heroic, target 25).
- The **Counterspell** spell (Greater, 3 mana) can be used as a reaction to another caster's spell. Caster rolls vs. $10 + \text{target spell's tier} \times 5$. On a hit, the target spell fails. The target keeps their mana — counterspelling is a spell duel, not theft.
- Otherwise, ongoing effects last for their duration.

These two spells are the only "anti-magic" toolkit in the game. There is no Antimagic Field, no Dispel Evil and Good as a separate thing, no Mage's Disjunction. If the GM wants a high-magic effect, they invent it for the story.

Rituals

A few spells (mostly Universal and Alteration spells of the Lesser tier) can be cast as **rituals** — performed slowly, over 10 minutes, with no mana cost. The spell entry says so.

Rituals exist to let casters do utility magic without spending mana. They can't be cast in combat. The classic ritual spells: *Detect Magic*, *Comprehend Languages*, *Mage Hand* (extended duration when ritual-cast), *Sanctuary*, *Identify*.

If a spell doesn't say "ritual," it isn't one.

Magic items

Magic items are not spells, but the same logic applies: an item does what it says, no attunement, no spell slots used. A wand might allow the holder to cast a specific spell for free; the wand's text says how often. Most magic items are passive — a flaming sword does extra fire damage; a cloak of fire resistance halves fire damage taken.

A character can wear/wield as many magic items as physically fit. There is no slot economy.

Caster vs. caster

When two casters clash, it's the same procedure — they take turns, cast spells, roll attacks vs. defenses. A caster usually has a high defense in their own pool — Mind, Spirit, or Charisma — and softer numbers in the other two. They target each other's weaker defense accordingly (a Charisma-caster's Mind is often the soft spot). Counterspell is the conversation.

What magic deliberately doesn't have

- Spell slots in nine levels.
- Upcasting.
- Concentration as a tracked status with saves.
- Spell components tracked as resources.
- Schools of magic as a *resource* sub-system. Schools organize the catalog and gate class access (19-classes.md), but they add **no extra economy** — no per-school slots, no school levels, no specialization meters.
- A divine-vs-arcane split. There is **one catalog**; classes differ by which **schools** they access and which **pool** (Mind/Spirit/Charisma) fuels them — not by separate arcane/divine lists.
- Subclass-specific spell lists.
- Domain spells.
- Bard "spells known" as a separate, smaller list.
- Warlock invocations as a parallel system.
- Sorcerer metamagic.
- Wild magic surge tables.
- Detect Magic as an always-on radar.
- A separate "spell save DC" stat. (The caster rolls; the target's defense is the static number.)

If a 5e caster asks about any of these, the answer is *not in this game; describe what you want to do and we'll find it in the spell list*.

10 — Spell Catalog

Every spell in the game lives here, organized by **school**. Spells are tagged by school only — your class (19-classes.md) decides which schools you can access, and your **pool** (Mind, Spirit, or Charisma) fuels and aims them.

How a spell works

Name (*Tier · School · ongoing/ritual/reaction if any*) **Range** — **Target** — **Cost** **Effect**.

- **Cast from your pool.** A caster's mana is **level + Mind**, **level + Spirit**, or **level + Charisma** (set by class). Every spell you can access is cast from that one pool; your **spell attack** = **d20 + pool + training** vs. the named defense.
- **School access** comes from your class. **Universal** spells (utility/meta) can be learned by any caster regardless of schools.
- **Tiers & cost:** Cantrip 0 · Lesser 1 · Greater 3 · Master 5 mana. **Ranges:** Close (adjacent) · Near (6 squares) · Far (line of sight).
- **No saves** — the caster always rolls (see 06-attack-and-defense.md). **One ongoing spell at a time** (see 09-magic.md) — this single rule is what stops a caster from stacking a summon, a buff, and a control effect at once.



Summoning rules (read once)

Several Conjunction spells (and class signatures) summon a creature or animate a weapon. Summons are **tethered**, not free extra turns:

- A summon appears in an unoccupied space within **Near**, allied to you.
- It **acts immediately after your turn** each round — no separate initiative slot. Directing it is free (part of your turn).
- It uses the **stat block in the spell** and lasts the spell's duration or until it drops to 0 HP.
- **A summon counts as your one ongoing spell.** You can have only one active at a time. If you go Downed, it vanishes.
- A **bound weapon** is *not* a creature — it's a spectral weapon you wield and attack with normally (no tether, doesn't use your ongoing-spell slot).

The Conjunction perk **Master Summoner** (+1 to a summon's attacks, +2 rounds duration) and the summoner class signatures hook into these rules.

Destruction (*damage*)

Cantrips

- **Spark** — *Near · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Armor**; 1d6 fire. Flammables ignite.
- **Frost Touch** — *Close · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Armor**; 1d4 cold, target's Speed halved until end of its next turn.
- **Shock** — *Far · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Armor**; 1d6 lightning. No cover bonus vs metal armor.
- **Sacred Flame** — *Near · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Spirit**; 1d8 radiant; target glows (negates Hide/Invisible) until end of its next turn.

Lesser (1)

- **Magic Missile** — *Far · up to 3 creatures · 1* — no roll; three 1d4+1 force darts, split as you like.
- **Burning Hands** — *Close · 3-square cone · 1* — attack vs **Armor** each; 2d6 fire.
- **Thunderwave** — *Close · 3-square cube · 1* — attack vs **Armor** each; 2d8 thunder, pushed 2 squares.
- **Ice Spike** — *Far · one creature · 1* — attack vs **Armor**; 2d8 cold and Speed halved 1 round.

Greater (3)

- **Fireball** — *Far · 3-square radius · 3* — attack vs **Armor** each; 6d6 fire (half on miss).
- **Lightning Bolt** — *Far · 10-square line · 3* — attack vs **Armor** each; 6d6 lightning (half on miss); hits allies in line.
- **Cone of Cold** — *Close · 5-square cone · 3* — attack vs **Armor** each; 6d6 cold (half on miss); Speed halved 1 round.

Master (5)

- **Disintegrate** — *Far · one creature/object · 5* — attack vs **Armor**; 10d10 force; if it drops to 0, reduced to dust (no easy revive).
 - **Fire Storm** — *Far · 5-square radius · 5* — attack vs **Armor** each; 8d6 fire (half on miss). Everything flammable burns.
-

✨ Restoration (*heal · ward · bless · undeath*)

Cantrips

- **Guidance** — *Close · willing creature · 0* — its next ability check within 1 min has **advantage**.
- **Resistance** (*ongoing*) — *Close · willing creature · 0* — **advantage** on its Spirit defense until your next turn.
- **Spare the Dying** — *Close · a downed creature · 0* — no roll; the creature is **stabilized** (still 0 HP, no longer dying).

Lesser (1)

- **Cure Wounds** — *Close · touch · 1* — heal $2d8 + \text{pool}$. No effect on undead/constructs.
- **Healing Word** — *Far · one creature · 1* — heal $1d6 + \text{pool}$; can wake a downed ally.
- **Bless** (*ongoing*) — *Near · up to 3 willing · 1* — each has **advantage** on its next attack.
- **Sanctuary** (*ongoing*) — *Close · one willing · 1* — attackers must beat your spell attack vs. their Spirit to target it (1 min, ends if it attacks).
- **Cleanse** — *Close · touch · 1* — end one condition (Poisoned, Burning, Frightened, Charmed, Blinded...).

Greater (3)

- **Mass Healing Word** — *Far · up to 4 in Near of each other · 3* — each heals $2d6 + \text{pool}$; wakes the downed.
- **Spirit Guardians** (*ongoing*) — *Self, radius Close · 3* — enemies ending their turn within 1 square take $3d8$ radiant (half if they spend a reaction to roll Spirit and beat your attack).
- **Revivify** — *Close · a creature dead ≤ 1 min · 3* — returns at 1 HP; body must be intact.

Master (5)

- **Heal** — *Near · one creature · 5* — restore all HP; end all conditions except Exhausted.
 - **Resurrection** — *Close · dead ≤ 1 week · 5* — returns at full HP; costs the caster **1 permanent Spirit** until next level.
-

✂️ Alteration (*physical manipulation* · *wards* · *buffs*)

Cantrips

- **Mage Hand** (*ritual*) — *Near* · *a spectral hand* · *o* — lift 10 lb, open unlocked doors, pour, push. 1 min (10 if ritual).
- **Detect Life** (*ritual*) — *Self*, *radius Near* · *o* — sense living and undead creatures (not exact position) for 1 round (1 min if ritual).

Lesser (1)

- **Shield** (*reaction*) — *Self* · *1* — when hit vs **Armor**, add **+5 Armor** until your next turn; can turn a hit into a miss.
- **Mage Armor** (*ongoing*) — *Touch* · *1* — target gains **+3 Armor** for 1 hour (only while in light or no armor).
- **Slow** (*ongoing*) — *Near* · *one creature* · *1* — attack vs **Armor**; Speed halved and its attacks at disadvantage (3 rounds).
- **Enhance** (*ongoing*) — *Touch* · *willing* · *1* — **advantage** on Might & Agility checks and +1 Speed (1 min).

Greater (3)

- **Fly** (*ongoing*) — *Close* · *willing* · *3* — flying Speed 8 for 5 min; falls if it ends aloft.
- **Telekinesis** (*ongoing*) — *Far* · *one creature/object* · *3* — move it up to *Near* each round (attack vs **Armor** to fling a creature: 4d6 + prone).
- **Haste** (*ongoing*) — *Near* · *willing* · *3* — +1 Speed step, **advantage** on attacks and Agility (1 min). (*No extra action — kept in budget.*)

Master (5)

- **Wall of Force** (*ongoing*) — *Near* · *wall 10×4* · *5* — impassable, shapeable, 10 min; immune to Dispel Magic.
 - **Polymorph** (*ongoing*) — *Near* · *one creature* · *5* — attack vs **Mind** (or auto if willing); becomes a beast (GM's pick) up to 10 min; reverts at prior HP when the beast form drops.
-

Illusion (*mind · fear · stealth · charm*)

Cantrips

- **Daze** — *Near · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Mind**; its attacks & checks at disadvantage until end of its next turn.
- **Sleight Hex** — *Near · one creature · 0* — attack vs **Mind**; the next attack against it (by anyone) has **advantage**.
- **Minor Illusion** — *Near · 0* — create a sound or palm-to-body-sized image for 1 min; a creature that studies it may roll Mind vs. your attack to disbelieve.

Lesser (1)

- **Sleep** — *Near · up to 2 creatures · 1* — attack vs **Mind** each; falls asleep (Downed, not dying; wakes on damage/shake/1 min). 30+ HP immune.
- **Charm Person** (*ongoing*) — *Near · one humanoid · 1* — attack vs **Charisma**; **Charmed** 1 hour or until you/allies attack it.
- **Fear** — *Near · one creature · 1* — attack vs **Charisma**; **Frightened** of you (3 rounds).
- **Disguise Self** (*ongoing*) — *Self · 1* — appear as another person of similar size for 1 hour; touch reveals the illusion.

Greater (3)

- **Hold Person** (*ongoing*) — *Near · one humanoid · 3* — attack vs **Mind**; **Stunned** 3 rounds; may reroll Spirit vs. your attack each turn to break free.
- **Invisibility** (*ongoing*) — *Close · willing · 3* — attacks against it have disadvantage, its attacks advantage; ends when it attacks/casts or after 10 min.
- **Terror** — *Near · all enemies in a 3-square radius · 3* — attack vs **Charisma** each; **Frightened** 2 rounds.

Master (5)

- **Dominate Mind** (*ongoing*) — *Near · one creature · 5* — attack vs **Mind**; you control its actions (one move + action on its turn) up to 1 min; it may reroll Mind vs. your attack each time it takes damage.
-



Conjuration (*summon · bind · teleport · banish*)

Cantrips

- **Bound Blade** (*ongoing*) — *Self · 0* — conjure a spectral weapon (**1d8** , uses your spell attack) for 1 min. A bound weapon, not a creature.
- **Spectral Shield** (*ongoing*) — *Self · 0* — +1 Armor until your next turn.

Lesser (1)

- **Summon Beast** (*ongoing*) — *Near · 1* — summon a beast (HP 10, Armor 13, attack **+pool → 1d6+2** , Speed 8) for the encounter. (*Tethered* — see *Summoning rules*.)
- **Web** (*ongoing*) — *Near · 3-square radius · 1* — attack vs **Armor** each; **Restrained** (Might vs. your attack to tear free); difficult terrain; burns for **2d6** .
- **Misty Step** — *Self · 1* — teleport to an unoccupied space you can see within Near.
- **Bound Weapon** (*ongoing*) — *Self · 1* — a stronger spectral weapon (**1d10** , your spell attack) for 10 min.

Greater (3)

- **Summon Elemental** (*ongoing*) — *Near · 3* — summon an elemental (HP 25, Armor 14, attack **+pool → 2d6** , Speed 6, resists its element) for the encounter. (*Tethered*.)
- **Spiritual Weapon** (*ongoing*) — *Near · 3* — a floating weapon attacks **+pool → 1d8** force on your turn each round, for 1 min. (*Tethered; you may move it Near each round.*)
- **Banishment** (*ongoing*) — *Near · one creature · 3* — attack vs **Spirit**; vanishes 1 min (outsiders may not return).
- **Dimension Door** — *Far · self + one willing adjacent · 3* — teleport both to a point within Far.

Master (5)

- **Summon Greater Spirit** (*ongoing*) — *Near · 5* — summon a mighty ally (HP 45, Armor 15, two attacks **+pool → 2d8** , Speed 8) for the encounter. (*Tethered*.)
 - **Banish** — *Near · one creature · 5* — attack vs **Spirit**; non-natives banished **permanently**; natives as Banishment.
-

△ Universal (*utility / meta — any caster may learn*)

- **Light** (*Cantrip*) — *Close · object · 0* — bright light, 6-square radius, 1 hour.
 - **Mend** (*Cantrip · ritual*) — *Close · object · 0* — repair one break/tear no larger than a sword.
 - **Detect Magic** (*Lesser · ritual*) — *Self, radius Near · 1 (0 ritual)* — sense presence/rough location of active magic for 10 min.
 - **Comprehend Languages** (*Lesser · ritual*) — *Self · 1 (0 ritual)* — understand any language for 1 hour (understand only).
 - **Counterspell** (*Greater · reaction*) — *Near · 3* — when a creature casts, roll $d20 + \text{pool} + \text{training}$ vs. $10 + 5 \times \text{tier}$; on a hit the spell fizzles.
 - **Dispel Magic** (*Greater*) — *Near · 3* — roll vs. $10 + 5 \times \text{tier}$ to end an ongoing magic effect.
-

Designer's notes

- **~65 spells across 5 schools + Universal.** Each school spans all four tiers, so any 2- or 3-school class has real choices at every tier.
- **Conjuration is a full pillar** — summons (tethered, one at a time = no action-economy bloat), bound weapons (for the gish classes), teleports, and the banish line.
- **Alteration is the "manipulate the physical" school** — flesh/ward (Mage Armor, Shield), telekinesis, Slow, Haste, Fly. Its **Arcane Ward** class perk lives here.
- **Save-or-suck stays disciplined.** Hard lockdown is rare: Sleep, Hold Person, Dominate Mind, Polymorph, Banish — spread across schools and tiers, each on a different defense, most with a recurring escape roll.
- **All four defenses see fire.** Damage and elementals hit **Armor**; sleep/illusion/paralysis/domination hit **Mind**; charm and fear (Charm Person, Fear, Terror) hit **Charisma**; banishment and death-magic hit **Spirit**. No defense is dead weight.
- **Healing still costs mana** — no free healing cantrip, preserving the resource economy.
- **Pools, not lists.** A Spirit-Paladin and a Charisma-Sorcerer both cast Fireball; it's the same Destruction spell from different pools. Class school-access is the only gate.

The list should never grow so large a new player can't read it in one sitting. **The total spell list fits in a player's head, not in an index.**

11 — Equipment

The equipment list is short. **A character's gear shouldn't be a spreadsheet** — it should be a few items they hold and use. We curate goods to the things that meaningfully change play.

Weapons and armor have their own sheets now: see 17-weapons.md (classes + the metal/stone material ladder) and 18-armor.md (light/heavy + the leather/hide and metal/stone ladders). This doc covers everything else — kits, consumables, tools, services, and magic items.

Gear

Adventuring kit (10g, standard starting kit)

The "you have whatever's reasonable" pack. Includes:

- Backpack
- Bedroll
- Tinderbox + 5 torches
- Waterskin (1 day's water)
- 5 days' rations
- 50-foot rope
- Whetstone or weapon-care basics
- Small mirror, signal whistle, chalk

A character with the kit has these things. We don't track them as individual line items unless something matters (the torch goes out, the waterskin runs dry in the desert). The kit costs **10g** to replace if lost.

Consumables

Item	Cost	Effect
Healing potion	50g	Action to drink. Restore 1d8 + 2 HP.
Mana potion	100g	Action to drink. Restore 1d4 mana. Rare.
Vial of acid	25g	Throw at Near range. Spell attack vs. Armor. 2d6 damage on hit.
Alchemist's fire	25g	Throw at Near range. Spell attack vs. Armor. 1d6 fire, then Burning condition.
Antitoxin	50g	Drink to remove Poisoned condition immediately.
Holy water	25g	Throw at Near range. 2d6 radiant damage to undead/fiends; no effect otherwise.
Smokebomb	30g	Throw at Near range. 2-square radius of smoke; full cover within. Lasts 1 round.
Caltrops bag	5g	Action to scatter. 1-square area of difficult terrain; creature entering takes 1 damage and may be Slowed (−2 speed) for the round.
Oil flask	5g	Lamp fuel. If thrown and ignited, alchemist's fire-equivalent.
Ration (day)	1g	One day's food for one person.

Tools, services, and miscellany

Item / service	Cost
Thieves' tools (lockpicks, picks, files)	25g
Healer's kit (10 uses, +5 to Medicine checks)	30g
Climbing kit (spikes, harness)	30g
Disguise kit	25g
Forgery kit	25g
Crowbar	2g
Hammer + 10 iron spikes	2g
Lantern + 5 flasks of oil	10g
Mage's spellbook (blank)	50g
Holy symbol	10g
Manacles	2g
Steel mirror	5g
Spyglass	1000g
Horse	75g
Stabling (per night)	5s
Inn (per night, common room)	5s
Inn (private room)	2g
Hireling (per day)	1g

We track only currency that matters. Silver and copper exist but most adventurers deal in gold.

Starting equipment

A new character starts with:

- **The apprentice-tier gear their class's components imply** (below), OR
- **50 gold** to spend à la carte.

Starting gear is **apprentice-tier material** (Iron/Steel weapons and heavy armor; Hide/Leather light armor). See 17-weapons.md and 18-armor.md for the ladders.

Build your kit from your class (19-classes.md): a weapon for each weapon *type* you're trained in (apprentice material), your **armor tier** (Steel heavy / Leather light / none), a shield if you want one and a hand free, a spellbook or holy symbol if you cast, plus the adventuring kit and ~`10g`.

Example kits by archetype:

- **Heavy fighter** (e.g., *Knight*): Steel heavy armor, a Steel + an Iron weapon of your types, adventuring kit, 10g.
- **Light fighter** (e.g., *Ranger*): Leather armor, Iron weapons of your types (e.g., longbow + daggers), thieves'/utility tools, adventuring kit, 10g.
- **Caster** (e.g., *Mage, Priest*): Leather armor (or robes), an Iron dagger, spellbook or holy symbol, adventuring kit, 15g.
- **Gish** (*half-caster / spellsword*): Leather or no armor, one martial or light weapon, a focus/holy symbol, adventuring kit, 10g.

Magic items

Magic items are not standardized. Each is a specific thing with its own text. There is no "+1 weapon" template that applies to every weapon; instead, *Anduril*, the captured elven blade, does what its description says. (Material grade is *not* a magic property — a Daedric sword is a mundane masterwork, not enchanted.)

That said, here is a small starter list of useful magic items the GM can hand out without inventing flavor:

Common (apprentice tier)

- **Healer's bracer.** +1 to all healing rolls cast by the wearer.
- **Cloak of warding.** +1 to Spirit defense.
- **Boots of the silent step.** Advantage on Stealth rolls when moving alone.
- **Quiver of returning.** Once per rest, when you run out of arrows, the quiver fills with 20 new ones.
- **Lantern of true sight.** While lit, illusion and invisibility within Near range fail.

Uncommon (veteran tier)

- **Ring of protection.** +1 to Armor, Mind, Spirit, and Charisma (all four defenses).
- **Flaming sword.** Standard weapon damage +1d6 fire on hit.
- **Wand of fire bolts.** Cast *Spark* at will using the wand's +4 attack bonus, regardless of the wielder's training.
- **Boots of striding.** Speed becomes 8 instead of 6.
- **Amulet of healing.** Once per rest, when you would drop to 0 HP, you instead drop to 1 HP.

Rare (master tier)

- **Vorpall blade.** On a natural 20 attack roll, if the target has a head, it is severed. (Functional decapitations: living things die. Constructs/oozes/undead-without-heads ignore.)
- **Staff of the archmage.** Mage holding the staff increases their mana pool by +3 per rest.
- **Plate of the unbroken.** Daedric heavy armor that also prevents the wearer from being knocked Prone.
- **Cloak of dimension door.** Once per rest, teleport up to 10 squares as part of a move.
- **Tome of binding.** A blank book. The first creature it captures is bound to its pages (a sub-game; the GM decides).

The GM should rarely hand out more than 2–3 magic items in a single tier. Each magic item is a story beat — where it came from, who lost it, why it surfaced now.

What equipment doesn't have

- Encumbrance tables.
- A weight stat on every item.
- A "magic item attunement" slot economy.
- Ammunition tracking. (You have arrows. If the GM thinks you've run out, they tell you.)
- A separate "magic weapon" requirement to hit certain creatures. (Magic items have their own effects; some monsters are resistant to non-magical damage and the GM will tell you.)
- A full price list for every conceivable object.

If a player wants something not on this list, the GM names a price and the answer is yes. **The currency is gold and time, not paperwork.**

12 — Monsters

A monster stat block fits on an index card. **That is the design target.** No two-page stat blocks, no nested ability lists, no nine specialty senses.

The stat block

```
NAME · Tier X · Threat Y
HP A | Armor B | Mind C | Spirit D | Charisma E | Speed F
Attack: name +G vs. defense → damage
Special: one or two short abilities
Notes: tactics, motivation, appearance
```

That's it. Eight lines. A new GM can run any monster in this book without preparation.

Field guide:

- **Tier** (1–3) is which player tier this monster is balanced for. Apprentice, Veteran, Master.
- **Threat** is the encounter-budget number for this monster (see 13-encounters-and-rewards.md).
- **HP, Armor, Mind, Spirit, Charisma** are static values. Monsters don't roll defenses — they're rolled against. (Charisma is the defense vs. charm, fear, and command — see 06-attack-and-defense.md.)
- **Speed** is squares per turn.
- **Attack** has a single +N attack bonus (which encodes ability + training), a target defense, and damage. Some monsters have two attack options.
- **Special** is one or two named abilities, each one sentence.
- **Notes** is free-text guidance for running the monster.

Monsters can have **Sentinel** (opportunity strikes are on for this monster). Add it to Notes.

Apprentice tier (levels 1–7)

Goblin Skirmisher — Tier 1 · Threat 1

- **HP** 7 · **Armor** 13 · **Mind** 10 · **Spirit** 9 · **Charisma** 9 · **Speed** 7
- **Attack:** *Scimitar* +3 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 1 (or thrown javelin, Near range)
- **Special:** *Nimble Escape* — disengages without provoking, even from Sentinel monsters.
- **Notes:** Cowardly in melee. Will flee at half HP unless commanded. Hunts in packs of 4–8.

Goblin Archer — Tier 1 · Threat 1

- **HP** 7 · **Armor** 12 · **Mind** 10 · **Spirit** 9 · **Charisma** 9 · **Speed** 6
- **Attack:** *Shortbow* +4 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 2, Range Far.
- **Special:** *Take Cover* — moves into cover after each attack; attacks against this goblin while in cover have disadvantage.
- **Notes:** Stays at the back. Targets casters first.

Goblin Boss — Tier 1 • Threat 3

- **HP 22 • Armor 14 • Mind 11 • Spirit 11 • Charisma 13 • Speed 7**
- **Attack:** *Wicked Blade* +4 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 2 . *Crossbow:* +4 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 2 , Range Near.
- **Special:** *Command* — once per round, a nearby goblin makes an immediate attack as a free action.
- **Notes:** Sentinel. Will sacrifice minions to escape if losing. Has a back exit ready.

Wolf — Tier 1 • Threat 2

- **HP 12 • Armor 13 • Mind 11 • Spirit 10 • Charisma 8 • Speed 10**
- **Attack:** *Bite* +4 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 2 . On hit, target is Knocked Prone if Tier 1 or smaller.
- **Special:** *Pack Tactics* — has advantage on attacks if an ally is adjacent to the same target.
- **Notes:** Pack hunter. Hits and retreats. Smart enough to flank.

Bandit — Tier 1 • Threat 1

- **HP 9 • Armor 13 • Mind 10 • Spirit 11 • Charisma 10 • Speed 6**
- **Attack:** *Shortsword* +3 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 1 . *Light crossbow:* +3 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 1 , Range Far.
- **Special:** *Surrender* — when below half HP and outnumbered, will drop weapons and surrender if offered.
- **Notes:** Human. Has a name, a back-story, a debt, a family. Use them; PCs will hesitate to kill if you do.

Bandit Captain — Tier 1 • Threat 4

- **HP 30 • Armor 15 • Mind 12 • Spirit 13 • Charisma 14 • Speed 6**
- **Attack:** *Scimitar* +5 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 3 twice per turn (this monster has Cleave-like *Whirlwind*).
Dagger: +5 vs. Armor → 1d4 + 3 , Range Near (thrown).
- **Special:** *Whirlwind* — on a turn where the captain has not moved, makes two melee attacks instead of one.
- **Notes:** A leader. Won't surrender — has a debt to a worse master.

Skeleton — Tier 1 • Threat 1

- **HP 13 • Armor 13 • Mind 9 • Spirit 9 • Charisma 6 • Speed 6**
- **Attack:** *Rusted blade* +3 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 1 . *Shortbow:* +3 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 1 .
- **Special:** *Immune to poison and the Charmed/Frightened/Poisoned conditions*. Vulnerable to bludgeoning damage (takes +1d4 from clubs/maces/warhammers).
- **Notes:** Has no fear, no fatigue. Will fight to dust.

Zombie — Tier 1 • Threat 2

- **HP 18 • Armor 10 • Mind 7 • Spirit 8 • Charisma 5 • Speed 4**
- **Attack:** *Slam* +3 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 1 . On hit, target rolls Spirit vs. zombie's +3 attack roll or is **Poisoned** (necrotic flavor) until cleansed or rest.
- **Special:** *Undead Fortitude* — when reduced to 0 HP by a hit that is not radiant or fire, roll d20: on 11+, the zombie has 1 HP instead.
- **Notes:** Slow but stubborn. Often comes in waves.

Giant Spider — Tier 1 • Threat 3

- **HP** 18 • **Armor** 14 • **Mind** 11 • **Spirit** 11 • **Charisma** 7 • **Speed** 6, climb 6
- **Attack:** *Bite* +4 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 2, on hit target rolls Spirit vs. spider's +4 roll or **Poisoned** for 1 minute.
- **Special:** *Web Shot* (recharge 5–6 on a d6): ranged spell-style attack at Near range, +4 vs. Agility → target is **Restrained** until they spend an action to break free (Might vs. +4).
- **Notes:** Climbs walls. Ambushes from above.

Orc — Tier 1 • Threat 2

- **HP** 18 • **Armor** 13 • **Mind** 9 • **Spirit** 10 • **Charisma** 10 • **Speed** 7
- **Attack:** *Greataxe* +4 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 2.
- **Special:** *Aggressive* — once per turn, the orc may move up to its speed toward a hostile creature it can see, in addition to its normal move.
- **Notes:** Berserker. Targets whoever hit it last.

Cultist — Tier 1 • Threat 2

- **HP** 11 • **Armor** 12 • **Mind** 13 • **Spirit** 13 • **Charisma** 12 • **Speed** 6
- **Attack:** *Ritual dagger* +3 vs. Armor → 1d4 + 1. *Cause Wounds* (cantrip, divine): +3 vs. Spirit → 1d6 necrotic, Range Near.
- **Special:** *Fanatic* — does not flee. Will fight to 0 HP. If reduced to 0 HP by a fellow cultist's spell, returns at 1 HP once per encounter (the dark patron pays).
- **Notes:** Dedicated to an evil power. Carries one ritual focus the party may need to destroy.

Ogre — Tier 1 • Threat 5

- **HP** 50 • **Armor** 12 • **Mind** 7 • **Spirit** 9 • **Charisma** 7 • **Speed** 7
- **Attack:** *Greatclub* +5 vs. Armor → 2d6 + 4. On a natural 20, target is also Prone.
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Big Reach* — its melee attacks reach 2 squares.
- **Notes:** The first boss-tier threat the party should fear. Dumb but hits like a truck. One hit can drop a Mage.

Veteran tier (levels 8–14)

Hobgoblin Soldier — Tier 2 • Threat 3

- **HP** 28 • **Armor** 16 • **Mind** 11 • **Spirit** 12 • **Charisma** 11 • **Speed** 6
- **Attack:** *Longsword* +6 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 3. *Javelin*: +6 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 3, Range Near.
- **Special:** *Martial Discipline* — gains +2 to attack rolls when an ally is adjacent to the same target (this stacks with flanking but doesn't double; if both apply, treat as advantage).
- **Notes:** Trained military. Holds formation. Hard to flank because they fall back together.

Hobgoblin Captain — Tier 2 • Threat 6

- **HP** 65 • **Armor** 17 • **Mind** 13 • **Spirit** 13 • **Charisma** 14 • **Speed** 6
- **Attack:** *Greatsword* +7 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 4, twice per turn.

- **Special:** Sentinel. *Battle Command* — once per turn, an allied hobgoblin within Near range may make a free attack as a reaction to the captain's order.
- **Notes:** A true tactical threat. Will divide and conquer.

Brown Bear — Tier 2 • Threat 4

- **HP** 40 • **Armor** 14 • **Mind** 10 • **Spirit** 13 • **Charisma** 9 • **Speed** 8
- **Attack:** *Claw* +5 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 4 . *Bite* +5 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 4 . Uses one of the two per turn.
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Crushing Hug* — on a hit with claw, target may also be Grappled (target's choice: take an extra 1d6 damage or be Grappled).
- **Notes:** Territorial. Won't pursue beyond its area.

Owlbear — Tier 2 • Threat 5

- **HP** 55 • **Armor** 14 • **Mind** 10 • **Spirit** 12 • **Charisma** 8 • **Speed** 8
- **Attack:** *Claw* +6 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 4 (twice per turn).
- **Special:** *Tear and Bite* — on a hit with the second claw, target is Bleeding (1d4 /turn) until tended.
- **Notes:** Unpredictable. Doesn't recognize danger to itself; fights to the death.

Will-o'-Wisp — Tier 2 • Threat 4

- **HP** 16 • **Armor** 15 • **Mind** 14 • **Spirit** 14 • **Charisma** 13 • **Speed** fly 8
- **Attack:** *Shock* +5 vs. Armor → 2d6 lightning, Range Near.
- **Special:** *Invisibility (at will, free action)* — when the wisp wishes, it vanishes. Spotted only by Lantern of True Sight or while attacking. *Consume Life* — if it touches a Downed creature, the creature takes 2d6 necrotic and the wisp regains all HP.
- **Notes:** Cowardly. Leads travelers to their deaths and feeds on the dying. Lures more than fights.

Ghoul — Tier 2 • Threat 3

- **HP** 22 • **Armor** 13 • **Mind** 9 • **Spirit** 10 • **Charisma** 7 • **Speed** 8
- **Attack:** *Claw* +4 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 2 . *Bite:* +4 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 2 , on hit target rolls Spirit vs. +4 or is **Stunned** until end of their next turn (ghoul paralysis).
- **Special:** *Immune to poison and the Charmed/Poisoned conditions.*
- **Notes:** Hunts in packs of 2–4. Targets stunned creatures.

Mage Apprentice — Tier 2 • Threat 4

- **HP** 22 • **Armor** 12 • **Mind** 15 • **Spirit** 12 • **Charisma** 11 • **Speed** 6
- **Mana** 6.
- **Attack:** *Quarterstaff* +2 vs. Armor → 1d6 . *Spark* (cantrip, free): +5 vs. Armor → 1d6 fire, Range Near.
- **Special:** Knows *Magic Missile* (1 mana), *Burning Hands* (1 mana), *Shield* (1 mana, reaction), *Sleep* (1 mana).
- **Notes:** A Mage trying to keep distance. Burn the apprentice down fast.

Knight — Tier 2 • Threat 5

- **HP** 55 • **Armor** 18 • **Mind** 11 • **Spirit** 14 • **Charisma** 14 • **Speed** 6

- **Attack:** *Longsword* +7 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 4, twice per turn. *Heavy crossbow*: +5 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 2, Range Far.
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Honor-bound* — once per encounter, if an ally adjacent to the knight would be hit, the knight may take the hit instead.
- **Notes:** Plate armor. Loyal. Will not flee.

Sahuagin Raider — Tier 2 • Threat 3

- **HP** 26 • **Armor** 14 • **Mind** 12 • **Spirit** 12 • **Charisma** 11 • **Speed** 5, swim 10
- **Attack:** *Spear* +5 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 3. *Bite*: +5 vs. Armor → 1d4 + 3.
- **Special:** *Blood Frenzy* — has advantage on attacks vs. creatures below half HP.
- **Notes:** Aquatic. Drags victims underwater. Hates surface dwellers.

Master tier (levels 15–20)

Vampire Spawn — Tier 3 • Threat 8

- **HP** 80 • **Armor** 16 • **Mind** 13 • **Spirit** 13 • **Charisma** 15 • **Speed** 8, climb 6
- **Attack:** *Claw* +8 vs. Armor → 1d10 + 5. *Bite*: +8 vs. Armor → 1d6 + 5 necrotic; on hit, spawn heals for damage dealt.
- **Special:** *Regeneration* — at the start of its turn, the spawn regains 10 HP unless it took fire or radiant damage in the previous round. *Immunities*: charm, sleep, poison. *Weaknesses*: vulnerable to fire and radiant damage (takes double).
- **Notes:** Sentinel. Can't enter a home uninvited. Hates sunlight (in sunlight, takes 2d6 radiant per turn).

Young Dragon (Red) — Tier 3 • Threat 12

- **HP** 180 • **Armor** 18 • **Mind** 15 • **Spirit** 16 • **Charisma** 17 • **Speed** 8, fly 16
- **Attack:** *Bite* +10 vs. Armor → 2d10 + 6. *Claw* +10 vs. Armor → 1d8 + 6 (uses one of them per turn; or both as below).
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Multi-attack* — instead of one attack, may make one bite and one claw in the same action. *Fire Breath* (recharge 5–6 on d6): a 6-square cone, spell attack +10 vs. Armor against each creature in the area, 8d6 fire damage on hit, half on miss. *Frightful Presence* — a creature that starts its turn within Near rolls Charisma vs. +10 or is **Frightened** 1 round.
- **Notes:** A regional boss. Has a hoard. Will negotiate if outmatched, but its pride is its weakness.

Lich (Apprentice) — Tier 3 • Threat 15

- **HP** 130 • **Armor** 17 • **Mind** 18 • **Spirit** 18 • **Charisma** 16 • **Speed** 6
- **Mana** 18.
- **Attack:** *Cold Touch* +10 vs. Armor → 3d6 cold + 1d6 necrotic, Range Close.
- **Special:** Knows: *Magic Missile* (1), *Fireball* (3), *Hold Person* (3), *Counterspell* (3), *Disintegrate* (5), *Wall of Force* (5). *Phylactery* — if reduced to 0 HP, body crumbles but lich is not truly destroyed unless phylactery is found and broken. *Immune to poison, charm, sleep, frightened*.
- **Notes:** Plans ten moves ahead. Has minions. Will retreat to phylactery and rebuild if killed without finding it.

Iron Golem — Tier 3 • Threat 12

- **HP** 200 • **Armor** 20 • **Mind** 5 • **Spirit** 9 • **Charisma** 5 • **Speed** 6
- **Attack:** *Slam* +10 vs. Armor → 3d10 + 6 . On hit, target Knocked Prone.
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Magic Resistance* — has advantage on all defenses vs. spells, and spells against it have disadvantage to hit. *Immune to poison, charm, sleep, frightened, fire (instead, heals 1d10 HP from fire damage)*.
- **Notes:** Slow but unstoppable. Often guards a single chamber.

Stone Giant — Tier 3 • Threat 9

- **HP** 130 • **Armor** 17 • **Mind** 10 • **Spirit** 12 • **Charisma** 10 • **Speed** 8
- **Attack:** *Greatclub* +9 vs. Armor → 3d8 + 6 . *Boulder:* +8 vs. Armor → 4d10 + 6 , Range Far.
- **Special:** Sentinel. *Rock Catching* — if hit by a thrown weapon or boulder, may try to catch it; roll d20 + 6 vs. attacker's roll; on success, no damage and giant may throw it back as a free action.
- **Notes:** Mountain dweller. Cautious. Throws boulders from range until forced into melee.

Building your own monsters

If you need a monster not on this list, use the following targets by tier:

Tier	HP	Armor	Attack bonus	Damage per hit
1 (apprentice)	7–25	12–14	+3 to +5	1d6 to 1d10 (+1 to +3)
2 (veteran)	25–80	14–17	+5 to +8	1d8 to 2d8 (+3 to +5)
3 (master)	80–200	16–20	+8 to +12	2d8 to 4d10 (+5 to +7)

A monster's Mind/Spirit/Charisma defenses are usually close to its Armor minus 1 to 3, except for elites and casters who have one defense significantly higher. Quick rules of thumb: **mindless** things (constructs, the shambling dead) have a low Charisma defense but are usually *immune* to charm and fear anyway; **leaders, fiends, fey, and casters** have a high Charisma defense (they don't rattle); **beasts** sit low on Mind and Charisma, higher on Spirit.

Scale within the tier. Each tier now spans several levels (Apprentice 1–7, Veteran 8–14, Master 15–20), and PC HP roughly **doubles** across the campaign (a level-20 heavy fighter pushes ~175 HP). Use the **low end** of a tier's HP/damage band for the early levels of that tier and the **high end** for the late levels — a Master monster for a level-20 party should sit at the top of the Master damage band (or above it for a boss) so fights don't drag against bloated HP pools. Attack bonuses stay put: the frozen d20 + 9 ceiling means tier-appropriate attack numbers don't need to climb the way HP and damage do.

A monster's threat number is roughly its Tier × 2, plus 1 for elite (named) status, plus 1 for any unusually nasty special, minus 1 for unusually fragile or limited. Six minions, four standard, two elite, one boss is a fine spread for a difficult fight.

A monster's name, motivation, and one weird thing matter more than its stat block. **A goblin who is afraid of fire**, played as such, is more memorable than a goblin with three extra abilities.

13 — Encounters and Rewards

How to build a fight that's challenging but fair, and what the party gets when they win.

The encounter budget

Use **threat points** (introduced in 12-monsters.md). Each monster has a threat number. To build an encounter:

Budget = party level × number of players.

A 4-player level 3 party has a budget of **12 threat points**.

- **Easy fight:** spend 50–75% of budget. Probably no resources used. Practice fight.
- **Standard fight:** spend 100% of budget. The party will use some spells / lose some HP, but won't be in real danger.
- **Hard fight:** spend 125–150% of budget. PCs may go down. Resources will be burned. Memorable.
- **Boss fight:** spend 200% of budget across one big monster + 2–3 minions, or one truly elite. Plan for the chance someone dies.

The 100%-of-budget fight is the median. The 50% practice fight teaches the system; the 150% hard fight punctuates the story; the 200% boss closes acts.

Encounter shapes

A few standard shapes to keep variety:

- **Pack hunt.** 4–6 small monsters, no leader. Wolves, goblins, skeletons. Tests positioning and crowd control.
- **Elite + minions.** 1 elite (50–70% of budget) + several minions. The classic boss-and-thugs shape.
- **Two threats.** 2 mid-tier monsters of different types — one melee, one ranged or caster. Tests target priority.
- **Solo.** 1 big monster (the full budget). Tests focus fire and survivability.
- **Wave.** Three rounds, monsters arrive in waves. Tests resource management.

Each session should mix shapes. **Don't run three pack hunts in a row.**

Adjusting on the fly

Even the best budget estimate misses. If a fight is going too easy or too hard:

- **Too easy:** add a reinforcement wave ("more goblins arrive at the door"). Don't buff the existing monsters mid-fight — players will notice. **New** monsters arriving is fair.
- **Too hard:** have wounded monsters flee. Have an environmental shift help the PCs (the support beam cracks, the cave wall collapses on the boss). Reveal that the elite is using an illusion to seem tougher than it is.

The encounter budget is a guideline, not a promise. **The story matters more than the math.**

Environmental factors

Some terrain and conditions effectively multiply the fight's difficulty without changing the threat budget:

- **Difficult terrain everywhere** (+25% to fight feel).
- **No cover** (+25% ; favors ranged enemies).
- **Heavy cover everywhere** (-25% if enemies don't use it well; +50% if they do).
- **Time pressure** ("the spire collapses in 6 rounds") (+50%).
- **Hostage / objective** (the party must protect or rescue something) (+50%).
- **Dim or no light** (PCs with darkvision or Light cantrip fine; otherwise +25%).
- **Multiple levels** (a chasm, a balcony, a rooftop) (+25%).

Stacking these is how a budget-100% fight becomes a memorable, dangerous moment. **Geometry and stakes are free encounter difficulty.**

Non-combat encounters

A "fight" isn't always a fight. Some encounters use the same threat budget for other resolution shapes:

- **Social encounter.** A noble's court, a smuggler's bargain, a cult's recruitment pitch. Resolved with rolls, but driven by player choice and NPC reactions. *Budget rule of thumb:* 1 named NPC per 4 threat points.
- **Skill challenge.** Crossing the freezing river, escaping the burning library, infiltrating the manor. The party rolls 3–5 checks (group checks or individual) against escalating targets; failure brings consequences but rarely outright kills. *Budget rule of thumb:* each failed check is 1 threat point of damage or condition spread across the party.
- **Hazard.** A trap, a magical storm, a haunted hallway. *Budget rule of thumb:* a single hazard worth 1–3 threat points, resolved with one or two rolls.

A campaign that is 100% combat will tire the party. **Mix fights with everything else.**

Resting between fights

Per 03-progression.md, there's only one rest. This means:

- **The party will choose when to spend resources.** A Mage who blows their mana on encounter one is empty for the rest of the day.
- **Encounters should sometimes come in chains.** Three fights between rests is meaningful; one fight, one rest, repeat is not.
- **The "adventuring day"** is 3–5 fights of varying intensity, plus some non-combat. After that, the party should be reaching for a rest.

If the party keeps trying to rest after every fight, **the GM should put time pressure on the dungeon.** Reinforcements arrive. The ritual completes. The princess dies. The party learns to push.

Rewards

Three currencies: gold, items, and information.

Gold

A rough scale by tier:

- **Apprentice tier:** 50–200g per significant encounter, 500–1000g per adventure.
- **Veteran tier:** 200–1000g per significant encounter, 1000–5000g per adventure.
- **Master tier:** 1000g+ per encounter, 5000g+ per adventure, mythic treasures (jewels, royal tribute) at climaxes.

Don't track every coin. Round to convenient numbers. "**You find about 200 gold's worth of plunder**" is a fine narration.

Magic items

A reasonable pace:

- **Apprentice tier:** 1–2 common magic items per adventure.
- **Veteran tier:** 1–2 uncommon per adventure, plus the occasional common.
- **Master tier:** 1 rare per adventure, plus occasional uncommons.

Magic items should mostly be **specific things with specific histories**, not generic `+1` weapons. A *Sword of the Drowned King* is a story. A `+1 longsword` is a number.

Information

The most underrated reward. A clue, a map, a name, a debt called in, a faction's secret, the name of a god — these are often more valuable than gold. **Hand them out generously.** Players who solve the next problem because of information they earned feel like heroes.

Treasure tables

To save GM improv when you need a hoard fast:

Apprentice treasure roll (1d6)

1. 50g coins
2. 100g coins + a silver dagger (worth 25g)
3. 80g coins + a healing potion
4. 150g coins + thieves' tools
5. 200g coins
6. 200g coins + one common magic item (GM picks)

Veteran treasure roll (1d6)

1. 300g coins + a healing potion + an alchemist's fire
2. 500g coins
3. 400g coins + a common magic item

4. 600g coins + a mana potion
5. 800g coins + a piece of jewelry (worth 200g)
6. 1000g coins + one uncommon magic item (GM picks)

Master treasure roll (1d6)

1. 1500g coins + a healing potion + a rare gem (worth 500g)
2. 2000g coins
3. 2500g coins + an uncommon magic item
4. 3000g coins + jewelry (worth 1000g)
5. 4000g coins + a mana potion + an uncommon magic item
6. 5000g coins + one rare magic item

Roll on a table when you genuinely don't care; pick from it when you do.

Pacing rewards

A common GM mistake: rewards arrive *after* the fight, so the players don't feel them in the moment. Try reversing this:

- **Reward inside the fight.** The boss is wearing the magic crown the party came for; mid-fight, the Scout could grab it.
- **Reward changes the fight.** The treasure chest holds healing potions; the party can reach them at the cost of an action.
- **Reward foreshadowed.** The party sees the reward at the start of the encounter, drives toward it.

The fight is more engaging when the *thing they want* is visible, not just inferred.

What this doc deliberately omits

- A full XP-by-monster table.
- A "challenge rating" system separate from threat.
- A treasure-by-CR table.
- Magic item rarity tied to gold value.
- Encounter math that requires a calculator.
- A list of every conceivable hazard, trap, or environmental effect.

If the GM wants a fight that isn't on a table, they think about *what should happen here* and pick monsters/hazards/NPCs to make it happen. **The budget is a sanity check, not a recipe.**

14 — GM Guide

How to run this game well. Most of it is advice, not rules.

Your three jobs

A GM has exactly three jobs at the table:

1. **Describe the situation.** What the players see, hear, and can plausibly do.
2. **Adjudicate the dice.** Decide when to call for a roll, what ability, what target. Then narrate the result.
3. **Play the world.** The monsters, the townsfolk, the wind in the trees. Everything that isn't a PC.

Everything else — encounter math, plot, foreshadowing, character arcs — is in service of these three.

Before the session

You need surprisingly little prep. **Five minutes is genuinely enough** for most sessions, if you have:

- **A starting situation.** Where the party is, what just happened, what's expected next. One paragraph.
- **A few NPCs.** Names, one weird thing each, what they want.
- **Two or three encounter ideas.** Don't pre-build them; just know who/what is there. You'll grab stat blocks from 12-monsters.md as needed.
- **One inevitability.** Something that *will* happen if the party doesn't act. The ritual completes. The duke's coronation begins. The dragon wakes. This gives you a clock to run.

You don't need a map drawn out. You don't need a planned plot. You don't need to know what the players will do. **You need a world that's alive, with a clock ticking somewhere in it.**

During the session

Calling for rolls

The single most common new-GM mistake is **calling for too many rolls**. Re-read 04-skills-and-checks.md. Default to *no roll* unless:

- The outcome is in doubt.
- The result will matter.
- Both success and failure are interesting.

If a player describes their character searching a desk, and there's a letter in the drawer, **they find the letter**. No Perception check. The roll would only stall the scene.

Picking the target

Three numbers exist on purpose: **10, 15, 20**. Don't invent 12 or 17. When in doubt, pick 15. The few minutes you'd save with a "more accurate" target you'll lose explaining it.

Narrating the roll

A roll has *result* (yes/no, total) and *narration* (what that means in the fiction). Always do both.

- Don't say "You roll 18. You hit. You do 7 damage."
- Say "You roll 18. Your blade slips between the orc's ribs — he grunts, hand to the wound. 7 damage."

Same numbers. The second version is the *game*; the first is a calculator. **Use the dice; describe the dice.**

Failing forward

A failed roll is the GM's invitation to push the story sideways, not stop it. Re-read 04-skills-and-checks.md's three failure types. The bad failure is "you don't open the lock." The interesting failures are "you open it, but you snap your last pick" or "you open it, and the door creaks loudly."

Pacing fights

A fight should resolve in **4–6 rounds**. If a fight is dragging into round 8, something is off:

- The party is being too cautious. Have the monsters do something aggressive.
- The monsters are too durable. Drop their remaining HP to dramatic levels mid-fight; nobody will notice.
- The fight is uninteresting. End it. Have the surviving monsters surrender or flee.

A 10-round fight is a *terrible* fight, no matter how well it's balanced. **The math is for setup, not for grinding.**

Handling rules questions

When a rule is unclear or missing, **rule fast in the player's favor and move on**. Note the call. After the session, decide if it should be a permanent house rule.

"Can I use my off-hand to grab the falling chandelier while I attack with my main hand?" *Sure. Make the attack at disadvantage; if you hit, you also grab the chandelier.*

That ruling took 4 seconds. A "let me check the book" answer takes 4 minutes. **Time is the most precious resource at the table.**

When you don't know

Three magic phrases:

- **"Let me think."** Buys you 30 seconds to actually think.
- **"What does X look like to you?"** Hands the description back to the player; they help you build the scene.
- **"Let's say yes."** When in doubt, the player's clever idea works. The story is more fun when their cleverness pays off.

A confident *yes* from a GM who doesn't know the rule is better than a hedged *no* from a GM who does.

Playing monsters

A monster has stats, and a monster has *behavior*. The stats are in 12-monsters.md; the behavior is your job.

Read the Notes line. It tells you the monster's motivation. A goblin runs. A skeleton fights to dust. An ogre breaks down doors. Run them differently.

Pick targets in character. A wolf bites whoever just hurt the alpha. An archer shoots the caster. A cultist shields its priest. *Don't always target the lowest-HP player just because it's "optimal."* Monsters aren't computers.

Use environment. A goblin hides behind a barrel. A bandit takes cover behind a comrade. An ogre swings the bench it's standing on. The monsters interact with the room.

Let monsters flee. Most things in the world don't want to die. When a monster reaches half HP and is losing, ask: *would this creature run?* If yes, they try.

Playing NPCs

NPCs are everyone else. Each one needs three things:

- **A want.** What do they push for in any given scene? *The innkeeper wants you to pay your tab. The lord wants a peaceful coronation. The cultist wants converts.*
- **One weird thing.** A speech tic, a scar, a habit, a hidden agenda. *He keeps polishing the same spoon. She never sits down. He flinches when you mention his brother.*
- **A reaction to the party.** Friendly, neutral, suspicious, hostile. The reaction can shift in scene.

You don't need a backstory unless the players ask for one. **Most NPCs are one scene.** Spend your prep on the recurring ones.

Playing the world

The world doesn't pause when the party isn't watching. **NPCs make plans. Time passes. The villain moves.**

Practical version: every session, before play, ask: *what's happened since last session?* Even small answers: the merchants have raised prices, a new banner is flying over the keep, a body washed up at the river. These tell the party the world is alive.

Telegraphing danger

Players should never feel ambushed by the rules. If a fight is going to be lethal, **signal that beforehand:**

- *The villagers cross themselves when they speak of the cave.*
- *The corpses you find on the road were killed with single bites.*
- *The boss has a name, and people are afraid of it.*

If the party charges in anyway, the death is on them. If the party retreats, they've won the moment — they read the situation correctly. **Either outcome is a good story.**

Avoid *gotcha* deaths: a trap with no warning, a TPK from an unsignaled hazard. Those teach the players to distrust the game.

Resource management as drama

The rest system from 03-progression.md gives you a powerful tool: **the dwindling Mage's mana pool, the warrior's HP bar, the priest's healing reserves** are all dramatic clocks. The party feels strong at the start of the day and exhausted at the end.

Push them. Make the third fight harder than the first. Make the fourth optional but tempting. Make the fifth a desperate gamble. **The arc of an adventuring day is a story arc.**

If the party is always at full resources, you aren't pushing hard enough. If they're always near death, you're pushing too hard.

Death in the campaign

When a PC dies, give it weight. **Don't gloss over it; don't immediately offer a resurrection.** A death is a story moment.

- Pause the action. Let the player narrate their character's final moment if they want.
- Have the surviving party react. Do they bury the body? Take a memento? Vow revenge?
- Decide whether resurrection is an option in this campaign at all. If it is, make it cost something — the spell is rare, the target's soul has wandered, a god demands a price.

A campaign where death is meaningful has stakes. A campaign where revives are routine has none.

Player agency

The most important word in this guide: **agency**.

Players make choices. The GM presents situations and adjudicates outcomes. **The GM does not write the players' choices.**

This means:

- Don't railroad. If the party decides to go around the dungeon instead of through it, let them go around.
- Don't fudge dice to "protect the plot." The plot is what happens when the dice land where they land.
- Don't punish creativity. If the player has a clever idea, lean toward yes.
- Don't gate scenes on rolls the player doesn't know about. If the player needs to know the duke is lying, let them know.

Your job is to make the world surprising, not the players predictable.

What to do when it's going badly

A few signals and responses:

Signal	Response
Players are quiet, looking at their phones.	Ask them directly what they'd find interesting. Then steer the next scene that way.
A fight is dragging.	Cut to the chase. Have the boss reveal its real form, the building collapse, the cavalry arrive.
The party is stuck on a puzzle.	Provide a clue via an NPC. Or let an investigation check reveal it. Don't make them suffer.
One player is dominating.	Address it gently between sessions, not in front of the table. Set up scenes that spotlight the others.
The rules are getting in the way.	Drop them mid-scene. Make a ruling. Look it up later.
The story is going off the rails.	Let it. The rails are an illusion; the story is whatever the table builds.

What to do when it's going great

Get out of the way. Describe what happens. Let the players run. **The best sessions are the ones where the GM does the least narrating and the most listening.**

A quick checklist

Before each session:

- ☐ Where is the party? What just happened?
- ☐ What NPCs might appear? (Name + one weird thing each.)
- ☐ What encounter ideas are in scope? (Pick monsters from the bestiary.)
- ☐ What is *moving in the background* that the party will discover?
- ☐ What is one thing I'd love to happen this session?

After each session:

- ☐ What did the players do that surprised me?
- ☐ What did they care about?
- ☐ What promised to come back next time?

Two lists, ten minutes. That's a campaign.

15 — Quickstart

The whole game, on one page.

The roll

d20 + ability + (training if you have it) vs. target number. Meet or beat the target = success.

Targets: **10 Easy** · **15 Hard** · **20 Heroic**. Default = 15.

Natural 20 = critical (double damage in combat, spectacular result outside it). Natural 1 = critical failure (a real complication).

Advantage / disadvantage

Roll 2d20, take the **higher** (advantage) or **lower** (disadvantage). One of each cancels. They don't stack.

This is the *only* situational modifier in the game. Any rule that wants to give a "+1" gives advantage instead.

Five abilities

- **Might** — physical force, toughness. Drives HP.
- **Agility** — speed, finesse, reflexes. Drives Armor for light-armored characters.
- **Mind** — reasoning, study, perception. Drives **studied** (arcane) magic.
- **Spirit** — will, faith, the soul. Drives **divine** / **primal** magic.
- **Charisma** — presence, persuasion, performance. Drives **innate** (sorcery/pact/song) magic.

Range: **-1** to **+5**. Assign **+3** / **+2** / **+1** / **+1** / **+0** at creation.

Classes

A class is a **combination of 3 components** — weapon types, an armor tier, and (casters) schools of magic. At level 1 you get **2 Signatures** (a Racial and a Class Signature); each component is a **2-perk track** you unlock over levels (6 perks by the master tier). **48 classes**; full roster in 19-classes.md. The old four survive as:

- **Knight** — medium+heavy weapons · heavy armor (*the old Warrior*)
- **Ranger** — light+ranged · light armor (*the old Scout*)
- **Mage** — Conjuration+Illusion · light armor · Mind pool
- **Priest** — Alteration+Restoration · light armor · Spirit pool

HP by armor tier: Heavy **10** · Light **8** · None **6** (+ Might). Your class grants **+1** to its one primary ability — and that single stat powers *all* your attacks, weapon and spell.

Trainings

Pick three at character creation (two from class list, one from background). Trained = add training bonus (**+2** / **+3** / **+4** by tier).

Defenses

- **Armor** = $10 + \text{Agility (or Might if heavy)} + \text{armor bonus}$ — physical, elementals
- **Mind** = $10 + \text{Mind}$ — illusion, sleep, psychic, domination
- **Spirit** = $10 + \text{Spirit}$ — banishment, death-magic, possession
- **Charisma** = $10 + \text{Charisma}$ — charm, fear, command

Combat turn

1. **Move** (default 6 squares).
2. **Act** — one action. Attack, cast a spell, dash, hide, help, ready, disengage, use an item, improvise.

No bonus action. No reaction by default. Side initiative (one roll per side).

Attack

$d20 + \text{primary} + \text{training}$ vs. defense. On hit, $\text{weapon die} + \text{material} + \text{primary}$ damage. Crit on natural 20 = double dice (flat mods added once).

Flanking grants advantage. Half cover = disadvantage. Full cover = can't target.

Weight rules: heavy gear plants you (**Set to Strike**) — move *and* attack the same turn → that attack is at disadvantage (heavy weapon *and* heavy armor → move *or* attack, not both). **No ranged weapons in heavy armor.** Two light weapons step the damage die up ($1d6 \rightarrow 1d8$).

Magic

Casters have a mana pool: $\text{level} + \text{pool}$ per rest, where **pool** is Mind, Spirit, or Charisma (set by class).

Spells are tagged by **school**; you cast from the schools your class grants, paying from your pool. Spells cost 1 / 3 / 5 mana (Lesser / Greater / Master). Cantrips are free.

Cast = pay mana, roll $d20 + \text{pool} + \text{training}$ if needed vs. target's defense (Armor / Mind / Spirit / Charisma).

One ongoing spell at a time. No concentration checks.

HP and death

At 0 HP, you go **Down**: unconscious, prone, dying. You'll die at the end of the next round if not stabilized (Medicine check, healing spell, or potion).

A rest = full HP + full mana + clears most conditions.

Conditions

Blinded, Burning, Charmed, Frightened, Grappled, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained, Stunned, Exhausted. Each is one rule. They don't stack with themselves.

The GM's job

- Describe the situation.
- Call for rolls only when failure is interesting.
- Pick the target (10/15/20).
- Narrate the result.
- Play the monsters and NPCs.

When in doubt: **say yes**, pick **15**, and **move on**.

What's gone (if you played 5e)

- No bonus action / reaction slot (unless a feature gives you one).
- No saving throws (the active player rolls; the defender has a static number).
- No spell slots; mana pool instead.
- No concentration checks.
- No multiclassing.
- No feats.
- No skill list of 18 (we have 17 trainings, you pick 3).
- No alignment, encumbrance, attunement, hit dice.
- No level 21+ (we cap at 20).

If a 5e rule you're used to isn't here, **the answer is: just describe what you're doing**. The d20 will sort it.

16 — The Co-GM Guide

This system assumes a human **GM** runs the table. This doc is for when a **co-GM** sits beside them — a second pair of hands (often an AI assistant) that rolls for monsters, tracks state, voices NPCs, and looks up rules. The GM owns the rulings; the co-GM carries the load.

These principles were distilled from live play. They're not adventure-specific — they apply to any session this system runs.

Division of labor

The co-GM is hands, not a head. It carries mechanical and narrative load so the GM can focus on the table. It does **not** make rulings.

The co-GM's job:

- Roll for **monsters, NPCs, and environment/hazards**.
- **Set up** player checks: name the ability, the target (10/15/20), advantage/disadvantage, and what's at stake.
- Track combat state — HP, conditions, initiative, positions.
- Track the clock and surface deadlines.
- Voice NPCs and read read-aloud text on cue.
- Suggest monster tactics.
- Look up rules and stat blocks.

The GM's job (never the co-GM's): **what's possible, when to roll, what a result means, how hard, who lives.**

Players roll their own dice

The co-GM **never rolls a PC's d20**. Rolling a player's dice steals the core moment of the game — their own roll under doubt. The pattern is always:

"Roll d20 + <ability> (+ training) vs. " → [tiered outcome preview] → **stop and wait for the result.**

Only the enemy/NPC side is auto-rolled.

Rule from the text, not the gut

Before telling a player something doesn't work, **check the written text** — the stat block trait, the spell entry, the rules doc. Do **not** invent restrictions or veto a legal tactic because it feels too strong.

Example from play: a player cast Sleep on a "Hag-Touched" enemy. The co-GM waved it off on a hunch. But the trait only blocked Frightened/Charmed — Sleep was legal. The text wins.

Players find the clever-but-legal line. **Honor it.** When genuinely unsure, surface the relevant text and let the GM rule.

Fail forward; never gate on one roll

A failed roll should **bend** the story, not **stall** it. Pick one:

- *You don't get what you want.*
- *You get it, but at a cost* (time, a complication, a frayed rope).
- *Something worse happens.*

Never let a single missed check black-hole a clue or dead-end the adventure. If a lead is essential, an NPC volunteers it, or the failure costs **time** instead of **information**. (The clock punishes; the plot doesn't lock.)

Tiered outcome tables

Decide *before* the roll what each result band yields:

Result	Meaning
< 10	miss / nothing / a complication
10–14	partial — the gist, not the gold
15–19	success — the real answer
20+ / nat 20	success <i>plus</i> a bonus the player didn't ask for

This removes mid-table waffling and makes a good roll *feel* good. Cheap to prep, big payoff at the table. The co-GM should present the tiers when setting up the check.

Reward creative tool-use

When a player reaches for an unexpected ability ("I read the tracks with **Wilderness**"), don't merely tolerate it — if it fits the fiction, it's often the *better* tool, and saying so rewards the creativity. Two good answers, never a flat "no":

- **"Yes, and"** (or *yes, but* with disadvantage if it's a stretch).
- **Hand it back:** "No, but tell me how *you'd* do it with what you've got."

Narrative craft

Humanize the mooks before the blades come out

A villain's pawn with a name, a family, and a keepsake **costs** the players something to kill. Foreshadow a doomed enemy through several NPCs before the fight, and the combat becomes the emotional peak instead of an emptied HP bar. Spend the setup; the payoff is enormous.

Seed mechanics in the fiction

If a fight has a "win button" (a ritual to disrupt, a true rhythm to ring, a weakness to exploit), **plant it in an earlier scene** so the player *earns* the knowledge in play. "I know this because of something I did" lands far harder than a handout.

Read-aloud vs. panel

Keep player-facing prose in quote blocks; keep mechanics, secrets, and tactics in a GM-facing panel below. It stops you from accidentally narrating the trap to the players.

Pacing & structure

The clock is pressure, not a gate

Track elapsed time, let failures *spend* it, and surface deadlines so they're **felt**. Let the clock drive player decisions (the fast-but-risky route vs. the safe-but-slow one). Pressure beats a hard fail-state.

Split freely in town; regroup before steel

Social and investigation splits are safe and great for sharing the spotlight — let the party fan out. **Combat** splits get someone killed (action economy is unforgiving). Know where the leash is: regroup the party before the first fight.

Let earned ambushes be decisive

A well-set ambush *should* be able to end a fight in one round. That's the **reward** for smart prep — not a bug to nerf. Don't begrudge players a decisive win they set up cleverly.

Scaling for party size

Encounters are budgeted by **Threat** for a 4-PC party. For a different size, adjust the budget:

- More PCs → add an enemy, or add HP to a boss.
- A PC who's **out of the fight** (carrying an NPC, holding a door) reduces the party's *effective* size — count it when scaling.

State scaling changes to the GM and let them pick the number.

The one-line version

The co-GM proposes; the GM disposes. Carry the dice for the enemies, set up the checks for the players, rule from the text, fail forward, and make the mooks matter.

17 — Weapons

Weapons have two parts: a **class** (what kind of weapon it is — sets the damage die, the ability, and the range) and a **material** (what it's forged from — adds flat damage). Everything else is flavor.

This sheet replaces the old "Weapons" section of 11-equipment.md. Armor lives in 18-armor.md; kits, consumables, and gear stay in 11-equipment.md.

The attack, unchanged

Attack = $d20 + \text{primary ability} + \text{training (if trained in this weapon class)}$ vs. the target's Armor. **Damage** = $\text{weapon die} + \text{material bonus} + \text{primary ability}$.

Every weapon uses your class's **one primary ability** (Might/Agility/Mind/Spirit/Charisma) for attack *and* damage — see 06-attack-and-defense.md. Training affects the **hit**, never the damage. Material affects the **damage**, never the hit.

Weapon classes

Class	Die	Ability	Hands	Range	Notes
Light melee	1d6 (1d4 dagger)	your primary	one	Close	throwable, concealable; dual-wield steps the die up
Medium melee	1d8	your primary	one	Close	the default fighter weapon
Heavy melee	1d10	your primary	two	Close	no shield/off-hand; <i>Set to Strike</i> (plant to swing — 19-classes.md)
Ranged	1d4 – 1d10	your primary	one or two	Near/Far	the weapon entry gives the range; not usable in heavy armor

All weapons use your class's primary ability. The classic associations (Might for heavy, Agility for bows) now only *suggest* which primary a class is built around — the stat you actually add is whatever powers your class.

Light melee — 1d6 (1d4 dagger)

Dagger (1d4 , throw to Near, concealable) · Shortsword · Hand axe (throw to Near) · Light mace / Club · Rapier.

Dual-wielding two light weapons (both hands, no shield): your damage die **steps up one size** — 1d4 → 1d6 , 1d6 → 1d8 . It's still **one attack per turn** (06-attack-and-defense.md); the off-hand blade is the upgrade, not a second strike. Versus a medium weapon, that's the **same 1d8 output without a shield slot**

— **but mobile and throwable**. A single light weapon keeps a hand free (for a shield, a torch, or a thrown follow-up).

Medium melee — 1d8

Longsword · Battleaxe · Warhammer · Mace · Spear (throw to Near; reach 2 squares — counts as polearm).
One-handed — pair with a **shield** (+2 Armor) or keep a hand free.

Heavy melee — 1d10, two-handed

Greatsword · Greataxe · Maul · Polearm / halberd / glaive (reach 2 squares). No shield or off-hand; **Set to Strike** — plant to swing (19-classes.md).

Ranged

Weapon	Die	Range	Notes
Shortbow	1d6	Near	
Longbow	1d8	Far	
Light crossbow	1d6	Far	slow reload (fire + reload consumes your move)
Heavy crossbow	1d10	Far	two-handed, slow reload
Hand crossbow	1d4	Near	one-handed
Sling	1d4	Near	improvised; anyone can use
Thrown (dagger/axe/spear)	1d6 / 1d6 / 1d8	Near	

Materials — the metal/stone path

Every weapon is forged from a material on the **metal/stone ladder**. The material adds a **flat bonus to damage** — the same bonus whether it's a dagger or a greataxe. (The same ladder also governs heavy armor; see 18-armor.md.)

Grade	Material	Power tier	Damage bonus	Typical price
1	Iron	Apprentice (lvl 1–7)	+0	10g
2	Steel	Apprentice (lvl 1–7)	+1	30g
3	Dwarven	Veteran (lvl 8–14)	+2	150g
4	Orcish	Veteran (lvl 8–14)	+3	400g
5	Ebony	Master (lvl 15–20)	+4	1,200g
6	Daedric	Master (lvl 15–20)	+5	3,500g

Two-handed weapons (heavy melee, heavy crossbow) cost roughly 1.5× the listed price; daggers and slings about half.

How the tiers work

Materials are **pinned to the power tiers**, not hard-locked to level. You'll *find and afford* Iron/Steel as an apprentice, Dwarven/Orcish as a veteran, Ebony/Daedric as a master — because that's what shows up as loot and what your purse can reach. A GM can hand a higher-grade weapon to a low-level party as **treasure** — it's a story beat, like a minor magic item, and it's powerful precisely because it's ahead of the curve.

Material on ranged weapons

Ranged weapons take a material too — it's the limbs, the head, the bolt-tips. A **Steel longbow** does $1d8 + 1 + \text{Agility}$; a **Daedric crossbow** does $1d10 + 5 + \text{Agility}$. Ammunition isn't tracked separately (per 11-equipment.md); the weapon's grade is what matters.

Crits and material

A natural 20 doubles the **damage dice** only. Material and ability are flat modifiers — added **once**, as normal.

Daedric greatsword crit: $1d10 + 1d10 + 5$ (material) + 5 (Might) — the dice double; the $+10$ does not.

Why material never touches the attack roll

The game's accuracy is **bounded**: the attack ceiling is $d20+9$, and target defenses sit in a known band per tier (see 03-progression.md and 18-armor.md). If materials raised *attack bonuses*, that ceiling would break and monster math would unravel. So material is poured entirely into **damage** — which is *not* bounded the same way (monster HP scales with tier to absorb it). You hit no more often with a Daedric blade than an iron one; you just hit far harder.

Worked examples

- **Apprentice Warrior, Might +4, Iron longsword (medium, trained):** attack $+4 +2 = +6 \rightarrow$ damage $1d8 + 0 + 4$ (avg **8.5**).
- **Veteran Warrior, Might +5, Dwarven greatsword (heavy, trained):** attack $+5 +3 = +8 \rightarrow$ damage $1d10 + 2 + 5$ (avg **12.5**).
- **Master Warrior, Might +5, Daedric greatsword:** attack $+5 +4 = +9 \rightarrow$ damage $1d10 + 5 + 5$ (avg **15.5**).
- **Veteran Scout, Agility +5, Dwarven longbow (trained):** attack $+5 +3 = +8 \rightarrow$ damage $1d8 + 2 + 5$ (avg **11.5**), $+1d6$ Sneak Strike when it applies.
- **Apprentice Mage, Mind +4, Steel dagger (untrained — pure casters get no weapon perk):** attack $+4 \rightarrow$ damage $1d4 + 1 + 4$ (avg **7.5**). Mind powers the blade just as it powers the spells. (*But spells are the Mage's real weapon; see 10-spell-list.md.*)

What weapons don't have

- Weapon properties as a tagged sub-system (Finesse, Versatile, Loading) — folded into class + one-line notes.

- A material bonus to the **attack roll** — material is damage only.
- Per-arrow ammunition tracking.
- Separate "masterwork" tiers *on top of* materials — the material **is** the quality tier.
- A magic-weapon requirement to hit certain monsters — magic items have their own text; the GM says when it matters.

18 — Armor

Two categories: **light** and **heavy**. Each is tied to one material path and one ability. The material a piece is made from **sets** its Armor bonus — there's no separate "base + material" stacking.

This sheet replaces the old "Armor" section of 11-equipment.md. Weapons are in 17-weapons.md.

The two categories

Category	Material path	Armor formula	Who's trained	Casting?
Light	leather / hide	10 + Agility + material	most classes	✓ all casting
Heavy	metal / stone	10 + Might + material	heavy-armor classes	✗ no spellcasting

- **Light** rewards Agility — it's the skirmisher's and the caster's armor. It never restricts your rolls, and **any caster can cast freely in light armor** (this replaces the old "any armor blocks arcane casting" rule).
- **Heavy** rewards Might and reaches higher Armor totals, but it's Might-locked and **blocks all spellcasting**. Only fighting classes wear it (see 19-classes.md).
- **No armor** is the unarmored caster's choice — Armor 10 + Agility (plus a shield) — taken by the naked glass-cannon classes to buy an extra component pick.
- **Heavy armor's combat cost** (see 19-classes.md): you **cannot use ranged weapons** while wearing it, and **Set to Strike** applies — if you *move and attack* the same turn, that attack is at **disadvantage** (and with a heavy weapon too, it's *move or attack*, not both). Heavy armor is the planted melee line.

Wearing armor you're not trained in

Disadvantage on all Agility and Might rolls, **and** you cannot cast spells. (A Priest in heavy armor: disadvantaged and silenced. Don't.)

Light armor — the leather/hide ladder

Agility-based. The material sets the bonus.

Grade	Material	Power tier	Armor bonus	Price
1	Hide	Apprentice (1–7)	+1	5g
2	Leather	Apprentice (1–7)	+2	20g
3	Studded leather	Veteran (8–14)	+3	120g
4	Scaled	Veteran (8–14)	+4	500g
5	Dragonscale	Master (15–20)	+5	4,000g

Light, by Agility: a Scout (Agility +5) in Scaled = $10 + 5 + 4 = 19$. A Priest (Agility +1) in Scaled = $10 + 1 + 4 = 15$ — the flat material still helps a low-Agility caster, even though Agility doesn't.

Heavy armor — the metal/stone ladder

Might-based. Same six materials as weapons (see 17-weapons.md); here the column that matters is the Armor bonus.

Grade	Material	Power tier	Armor bonus	Price
1	Iron	Apprentice (1–7)	+3	75g
2	Steel	Apprentice (1–7)	+4	200g
3	Dwarven	Veteran (8–14)	+5	800g
4	Orcish	Veteran (8–14)	+6	2,000g
5	Ebony	Master (15–20)	+7	5,000g
6	Daedric	Master (15–20)	+8	12,000g

Heavy, by Might: a Warrior (Might +4) in Iron = $10 + 4 + 3 = 17$ at level 1. The same Warrior (Might +5) in Daedric = $10 + 5 + 8 = 23$ at level 10.

Shields — +1 / +2 / +3, flat

Shields are the one thing that **adds on top** of your Armor. They are deliberately **material-agnostic** (a flat additive — letting them scale by material too would break bounded accuracy).

Shield	Bonus	Notes
Buckler	+1	
Shield	+2	
Tower shield	+3	counts as both hands; treats difficult terrain as -2 Speed

One-handed slot — can't be used with two-handed weapons. A shield doesn't interfere with a Priest's divine casting in light armor.

Expected defenses by tier (*for monster design*)

This is the spine of the bounded math. Materials are pinned to the power tiers so that monster attack bonuses, built per tier, keep pace. Build encounters against roughly these Armor values:

Power tier	Light wearer (Agi primary)	Heavy wearer (Might primary)	Unarmored caster
Apprentice (1–7)	15–17	16–18	11–13
Veteran (8–14)	17–19	19–21	12–14
Master (15–20)	19–20	21–23	13–15

A Tier-1 monster should be able to land on a 16–18 Armor on a meaningful fraction of swings; a Tier-3 monster, on a 21–23. If you hand a party gear *above* their tier (treasure), expect them to be harder to hit until the monsters catch up — that's the intended reward, used sparingly.

Worked examples

- **Apprentice Scout, Agi +5, Leather:** $10 + 5 + 2 = 17$.
- **Apprentice Warrior, Might +4, Steel + Shield:** $10 + 4 + 4 + 2 = 20$.
- **Veteran Priest, Agi +1, Studded leather:** $10 + 1 + 3 = 14$, casts freely.
- **Master Warrior, Might +5, Daedric + Tower shield:** $10 + 5 + 8 + 3 = 26$ — the hardest target the game produces. (Pair it with the loss of both hands and no casting.)

What armor doesn't have

- A **medium** category. (Folded away: light + heavy only. Old chain shirts → re flavor as light or low heavy.)
- An Agility **cap** on light armor. (That was a medium-armor rule; gone.)
- A "base + material" stack — the material **is** the bonus.
- Material-scaled shields — shields are a flat $+1/+2/+3$.
- Encumbrance, don/doff timers, or per-piece slot tracking. (One armor, optionally one shield.)
- Spellcasting in heavy armor, for anyone.

19 — Classes (the component system)

This chapter defines every class, superseding the old four. Each of the **48 classes** is generated from the same component vocabulary used everywhere else in the book — weapon types (17-weapons.md), armor tiers (18-armor.md), and schools of magic (10-spell-list.md). Character creation (02-character-creation.md) points here for the roster.

How classes are generated

A class is a **legal combination of components**. Pick a template, fill its slots, and you have a class — that's the whole generator. Everything below is the rules that decide which combinations are legal and balanced.

The components

- **Weapon types:** Light · Medium · Heavy · Ranged
- **Armor tiers:** Light · Heavy · None
- **Schools of magic:** Destruction · Conjunction · Alteration · Illusion · Restoration

The legal templates

Fighting classes (*no magic*):

Template	Slots
Armored	2 weapon types + 1 armor tier (light or heavy)
Naked weapon-master	3 weapon types + no armor

Magic classes (*cast from a pool; light or no armor only — heavy blocks casting*):

Template	Slots
Half-caster	1 school + 1 weapon type + light armor
Spellsword	2 schools + 1 martial weapon (medium/heavy) + no armor
Caster	2 schools + light armor
Full caster	3 schools + no armor

The build economy (the balance spine)

Every class is built from exactly 3 components. A component is *1 weapon type*, *1 school*, or *1 armor tier*.

- Baseline = **2 picks (weapons/schools) + an armor tier** = 3 components.

- **Going naked (no armor) buys a 3rd pick** but drops you to the lowest HP *and* Armor — the glass-cannon bargain.
- **Each component is a 2-perk track** — a *basic* perk and an *advanced* perk (the tracks below). You **unlock these as you level**, not at creation: a class's full kit is **6 perks**, gained one at a time across the campaign (03-progression.md).
- On top of the components, every character gets **2 Signatures at level 1**: a **Racial Signature** (your ancestry trait, 02-character-creation.md) and a unique **Class Signature** (below). These are your identity from turn one.
- A build is legal **iff it lands on 3 components** — still checkable by counting. And because the unlock schedule is fixed, **every character of a given level has the same number of abilities** (2 signatures + the perks unlocked so far).
- **No build exceeds 3 components**. So you can't have 2 schools *and* a weapon *and* armor (that's 4): a 2-school gish goes **naked** (the **Spellsword** — its weapon and spells share one stat, so being lightly built is fine), and an *armored* gish takes only **1 school** (the **Half-caster**). The armored 2-school war-mage simply doesn't exist — by design.

HP & primary ability

- **HP rides the armor tier**: Heavy $10 + \text{Might}$ · Light $8 + \text{Might}$ · None $6 + \text{Might}$. Per-level gain $1d6 + \text{Might}$ (1s/2s count as 3).
- **Your class grants +1 to its primary ability**. Primary is set **by feel**: Might for medium/heavy weapons, Agility for light/ranged builds; Mind, Spirit, or Charisma (the **pool**) for casters. It is *not* a separate combination axis. A caster's pool also reflects the *source* of their magic — Mind for the studied, Spirit for the devoted, Charisma for the innate.
- **Your primary powers everything**. Every weapon attack, weapon damage, and spell attack uses your one primary ability (06-attack-and-defense.md). A Mind-Battlemage's blade *and* its fire both run off Mind; a Might-Knight's everything runs off Might. One stat, whole character — which is what lets a gish wield a real weapon without splitting its ability investment.

The weight rules (what heavy gear costs)

- ① **Heavy weapons are two-handed**. No shield, no off-hand. Medium and light are one-handed.
- ② **No ranged weapons in heavy armor**. Heavy armor is the melee line — you cannot use bows, crossbows, or thrown weapons while wearing it. Archers and skirmishers live in light or no armor. (*This is why every heavy-armor class is a Might melee build — and why there's no tanky-archer.*)
- ③ **Set to Strike — heavy gear plants you**. On a turn where you **move and attack**:
 - wielding a **heavy weapon** *or* wearing **heavy armor** → that **attack is at disadvantage**;
 - wielding a heavy weapon *and* wearing heavy armor → you **can't do both: take your move or your attack this turn, not both**.

Stand your ground (use no movement) and you strike normally. (*Disadvantage is binary — 01-core-mechanic.md — so the "both heavy" case escalates to denial rather than stacking dice.*) This gives heavy gear a real cost without a speed stat: **heavy = the immovable melee anchor; light/none = mobile**. It also synergizes with the perks — heavy armor's **Bulwark** and heavy weapons reward planting; light armor's **Slip Away** rewards moving.

Spellcasting access

A magic class casts from one **pool** (`level + Mind` , `level + Spirit` , or `level + Charisma`), knows 2 cantrips + the spells-known table (09-magic.md), drawn from its accessible **schools** (10-spell-list.md). Cast freely in light or no armor; **heavy armor blocks casting** (so no magic class wears it). Casters are trained in casting (spell attack = `d20 + pool + training`).

Component perk tracks

Each component is a **2-perk track**: a **basic** perk and an **advanced** one. You unlock perks on your perk levels (3 / 6 / 9 then 12 / 15 / 18 — 03-progression.md), basics first; a component's **advanced** perk requires you already hold its **basic** perk. By level 18 you hold all 6 perks of your 3 components.

Weapon tracks

Component	Basic	Advanced
Light	Sneak Strike — once per turn, when you attack with advantage or an ally is adjacent to your target, deal +1d6 on a hit.	Shadowstrike — your Sneak Strike die becomes +2d6 ; the first time each combat you hit a creature that hasn't acted yet, it's +3d6 .
Medium	Riposte — once per round, when a creature misses you in melee, immediately make one weapon attack against it.	Riposte Mastery — Riposte triggers when an enemy hits or misses you in melee (still 1/round), and the riposte attack has advantage .
Heavy	Cleave — when your attack drops a creature to 0 HP, make another attack against a different target in reach, same action.	Reaving Sweep — once per turn deal +1d10 on a hit; and Cleave now also chains off a hit that drops a target below half HP , not only to 0.
Ranged	Deadeye — your ranged attacks ignore half-cover. Once per turn, if your target is at Far range, deal +1d6 on a hit.	Piercing Volley — once per turn your ranged attack strikes every creature in a line to your target (roll each separately) and ignores all cover.

Armor tracks

Component	Basic	Advanced
Light armor	Slip Away — when an adjacent enemy takes an action that isn't attacking you, move up to half your Speed without provoking.	Evasion — when an area effect rolls against your Armor, a hit deals half , a miss deals none ; and Slip Away no longer needs the enemy to skip attacking you.
Heavy armor	Bulwark — allies adjacent to you have +1 Armor . (<i>A flat bonus to a static defense — permitted; the "no stacking +1" rule governs d20 rolls.</i>)	Immovable — you can't be moved, knocked Prone , or Grappled against your will, and your Bulwark bonus rises to +2 Armor .

School tracks

Component	Basic	Advanced
Destruction	Devastation — once per turn, reroll 1s and 2s on a Destruction spell's damage dice.	Overload — once per rest, maximize all the damage dice of one Destruction spell you cast.
Conjuration	Master Summoner — your summons get +1 to attack and last 2 extra rounds (see Summoning, 10-spell-list.md).	Greater Binding — your summons gain +1d6 to attacks and +10 HP ; your bound weapons step up one die (1d8 → 1d10).
Alteration	Arcane Ward — while you have 1+ mana , you gain +2 Armor .	Greater Ward — your Arcane Ward rises to +3 Armor , and once per rest you may extend a +3 ward to a touched ally for 1 minute.
Illusion	Beguiling — creatures roll at disadvantage to resist or break free of your Illusion effects.	Shatter Will — once per rest, a creature in Near rolls its lowest mental defense (Mind/Spirit/Charisma) vs. your spell attack or is Stunned until the end of its next turn.
Restoration	Divine Touch — as your action, touch a creature to heal 1d6 + pool . Usable 1 + pool times per rest.	Greater Mending — your Divine Touch heals 2d6 + pool and may be used at Near range (no touch needed).

Signatures (your identity)

Two unique abilities define who you are. Both are granted at **level 1** and never have to be earned:

- **Class Signature** — the one thing only your class does, tuned to ≈ a perk in power (unique, not stronger). The 48 are listed under *Class signatures* below. *(These were the old "override" perks — they now stand on their own at level 1 instead of swapping for a component perk.)*
- **Racial Signature** — your ancestry's trait (02-character-creation.md).

At the **level-20 capstone**, your Class Signature **ascends** to a master version — as a rule of thumb: double its dice, drop a "once per rest" limit, or widen its range or targets — but **never a second action**. The GM signs off on the upgrade in the spirit of the original. *(Per-class ascensions are a content pass; until then, use this rule.)*

How the original four map

Old class	New class (#)	Components	Basic-rung perks
Warrior	Knight (#9)	Medium + Heavy · Heavy armor · Might	Riposte · Cleave · Bulwark
Scout	Ranger (#3)	Light + Ranged · Light armor · Agility	Sneak Strike · Deadeye · Slip Away
Mage	Mage (#34)	Conjuration + Illusion · Light armor · Mind	Master Summoner · Beguiling · Slip Away
Priest	Priest (#37)	Alteration + Restoration · Light armor · Spirit	Arcane Ward · Divine Touch · Slip Away

(The perks shown are each component's **basic** rung — unlocked over levels 3/6/9, with the matching **advanced** rung following at 12/15/18. Each class also has its **Class Signature** plus a **Racial Signature** from level 1.)

Building a character (revised step 2 of 02-character-creation.md)

1. Assign abilities +3 / +2 / +1 / +1 / +0 .
2. **Pick a class** → +1 to its primary, weapon/armor/school training, HP tier, mana (if any), your **Class Signature**, and the **component perk tracks** you'll unlock as you level.
3. Ancestry (+1 + **Racial Signature**). 4. Background (+1 training). 5. Three trainings (4 if Human). 6. Defenses, equipment, spells.

The 48-class roster

✂ Fighting — armored (2 weapons + 1 armor)

#	Class	Weapons	Primary	Armor	HP
1	Duelist	Light + Medium	Might	Light	Mid
2	Reaver	Light + Heavy	Might	Light	Mid
3	Ranger	Light + Ranged	Agility	Light	Mid
4	Berserker	Medium + Heavy	Might	Light	Mid
5	Skirmisher	Medium + Ranged	Might	Light	Mid
6	Outrider	Heavy + Ranged	Might	Light	Mid
7	Sentinel	Light + Medium	Might	Heavy	High
8	Vanguard	Light + Heavy	Might	Heavy	High
9	Knight	Medium + Heavy	Might	Heavy	High

(Heavy-armor classes carry no ranged weapon, per weight rule ②.)

🗡️ **Fighting — naked weapon-master (3 weapons, no armor) — HP Low**

#	Class	Weapons	Primary
10	Gladiator	Light + Medium + Heavy	Might
11	Blademaster	Light + Medium + Ranged	Might
12	Marauder	Light + Heavy + Ranged	Might
13	Weaponmaster	Medium + Heavy + Ranged	Might

🔮 **Half-caster (1 school + light weapon + light armor) — HP Mid**

#	Class	School	Pool
14	Spellblade	Destruction	Mind
15	Adept	Conjuration	Mind
16	Warden	Alteration	Spirit
17	Trickster	Illusion	Charisma
18	Acolyte	Restoration	Spirit

🧙 **Spellsword (2 schools + martial weapon, no armor) — HP Low**

#	Class	Schools	Pool
19	Death Knight	Conjuration + Destruction	Spirit
20	Battlemage	Alteration + Destruction	Mind
21	Hexblade	Destruction + Illusion	Charisma
22	Paladin	Destruction + Restoration	Spirit
23	Spellforged	Alteration + Conjuration	Mind
24	Witch-blade	Conjuration + Illusion	Charisma
25	Wraith Knight	Conjuration + Restoration	Spirit
26	Mindblade	Alteration + Illusion	Mind
27	Cleric-Knight	Alteration + Restoration	Spirit
28	Sword-Bard	Illusion + Restoration	Charisma

✨ Caster (2 schools + light armor) — HP Mid

#	Class	Schools	Pool
29	Warlock	Conjuration + Destruction	Charisma
30	Sorcerer	Alteration + Destruction	Charisma
31	Mentalist	Destruction + Illusion	Mind
32	Templar	Destruction + Restoration	Spirit
33	Artificer	Alteration + Conjuration	Mind
34	Mage	Conjuration + Illusion	Mind
35	Shaman	Conjuration + Restoration	Spirit
36	Enchanter	Alteration + Illusion	Charisma
37	Priest	Alteration + Restoration	Spirit
38	Bard	Illusion + Restoration	Charisma

📖 Full caster (3 schools, no armor) — HP Low

#	Class	Schools	Pool
39	Elementalist	Alteration + Conjuration + Destruction	Mind
40	Archmage	Conjuration + Destruction + Illusion	Mind
41	Necromancer	Conjuration + Destruction + Restoration	Spirit
42	Spellmystic	Alteration + Destruction + Illusion	Mind
43	Oracle	Alteration + Destruction + Restoration	Spirit
44	Witch	Destruction + Illusion + Restoration	Charisma
45	Mystic	Alteration + Conjuration + Illusion	Charisma
46	Druid	Alteration + Conjuration + Restoration	Spirit
47	Spiritualist	Conjuration + Illusion + Restoration	Spirit
48	Seer	Alteration + Illusion + Restoration	Spirit

Class signatures — descriptions & abilities

Each class's one-line identity and its unique **Class Signature**, granted at level 1 (the ability marked ↪). 🌶 = flagged for playtest.

Fighting — armored

- **1 • Duelist** — *A nimble blade-dancer who turns a foe's commitment into an opening.* ↪ **En Garde:** mark a creature you hit in melee; while marked it has disadvantage attacking anyone but you, and you

have advantage on Riposte against it.

- **2 • Reaver** — *A savage raider who fights harder as the wounds pile up.* ↳ **Bloodlust:** while below half HP, your melee attacks deal +1d6 and you're immune to Frightened.
- **3 • Ranger** — *A wilderness hunter who marks prey and never loses it.* ↳ **Hunter's Mark:** mark a creature (free, 1/turn); your attacks against it ignore cover and deal +1d6. Re-marks on a kill.
- **4 • Berserker** — *A reckless warrior who trades skin for slaughter.* ↳ **Rage** (free, 1/rest, 1 min): melee attacks +1d6 and advantage on Might, but attacks against you have advantage.
- **5 • Skirmisher** — *A mobile soldier who strikes and slips away.* ↳ **Hit and Run:** after you attack, move up to half your Speed without provoking.
- **6 • Outrider** — *A roving heavy hitter who softens foes at range, then closes.* ↳ **Overwhelm:** when you hit with a ranged attack, your next melee attack vs. that target has advantage (and vice-versa).
- **7 • Sentinel** — *An immovable guardian who punishes anyone who ignores them.* ↳ **Guardian's Wrath:** when an enemy in reach attacks an ally (not you), immediately make a melee attack against it.
- **8 • Vanguard** — *The first through the breach, an armored spearhead.* ↳ **Breach:** as your action, charge your full Speed in a line and attack; on a hit, knock the target Prone. (Note: as a double-heavy build, this is its move-or-attack turn.)
- **9 • Knight** — *A disciplined heavy fighter, the wall the line forms around. (the old Warrior)* ↳ **Second Wind:** once per rest, as part of any action, regain 1d6 + level HP.

Fighting — naked weapon-master

- **10 • Gladiator** — *A crowd-pleasing arena fighter who feeds on the kill.* ↳ **Adrenaline:** each time you drop a creature to 0 HP, your next attack this round deals +1d6.
- **11 • Blademaster** — *A peerless weapon artist who answers steel with steel.* ↳ **Deflect:** once per round, when hit, reduce the damage by 1d8 + primary.
- **12 • Marauder** — *A brutal pillager who finishes the wounded without mercy.* ↳ **Pillage:** your attacks against creatures below half HP deal +1d8.
- **13 • Weaponmaster** — *A master of every armament — devastating, but exposed.* ↳ **Stance:** at the start of your turn, choose +1d6 damage **or** +2 Armor until your next turn.

Half-caster

- **14 • Spellblade** — *A warrior-mage who sheathes fire in steel.* ↳ **Spellstrike:** on a weapon hit, spend 1 mana to add 1d8 Destruction damage (your element).
- **15 • Adept** — *A novice summoner backed by a conjured ally.* ↳ **Bonded Blade** (1/rest, no mana): conjure a spectral weapon that fights on your turn for the encounter (your spell attack, 1d8).
- **16 • Warden** — *A protector who hardens flesh against harm.* ↳ **Stoneflesh:** as your action, grant yourself or a touched ally +3 Armor (ongoing, 1 min).
- **17 • Trickster** — *A deceiver who strikes from a fold in perception.* ↳ **Vanishing Act:** once per round after you attack, briefly vanish — attacks against you have disadvantage and your next attack has advantage.
- **18 • Acolyte** — *A field medic who mends as they fight.* ↳ **Battle Prayer:** once per rest, every ally in Near regains 1d6 + pool HP.

Spellsword (*naked, 2 schools + a martial weapon*)

- **19 • Death Knight** — *A grim warrior wreathed in necrotic power and raised servants.* ↳ **Soul Reap:** when you drop a creature with a weapon attack, regain 1d6 mana (max your pool).
- **20 • Battlemage** — *An armored-in-magic blaster who fights in the thick of it.* ↳ **Runic Weapon:** your weapon attacks deal +1d6 of a chosen element (fire/frost/shock). An at-will rider — no extra action.
- **21 • Hexblade** — *A cursed blade that unmakes mind and body together.* ↳ **Hex:** mark a creature (free, 1/turn); your spells and attacks vs. it deal +1d6 and it has disadvantage on its first attack each round.
- **22 • Paladin** — *A holy warrior of smiting wrath and mending light.* ↳ **Divine Smite:** on a weapon hit, spend 1–3 mana to deal 1d8 radiant per mana.
- **23 • Spellforged** — *An artificer-warrior clad in conjured arms and wards.* ↳ **Arsenal** (1/rest): conjure a bound weapon (1d10, your spell attack) and +2 Armor for the encounter.
- **24 • Witch-blade** — *A fey-touched duelist flanked by phantasms.* ↳ **Phantom Double** (1/rest): an illusory twin grants you disadvantage-to-be-hit until first struck, and once grants you advantage.
- **25 • Wraith Knight** — *A deathless sentinel who siphons life to endure.* ↳ **Lifedrain:** on a weapon hit, spend 1 mana to heal yourself 1d6.
- **26 • Mindblade** — *A psionic warrior whose blade is an extension of will.* ↳ **Psychic Lash:** once per turn, your weapon attack targets **Mind** (psychic); on a hit the target has disadvantage on its next attack.
- **27 • Cleric-Knight** — *A consecrated guardian who shields and heals in armor of faith.* ↳ **Aegis:** once per round, when an ally in Near is hit, reduce that damage by 1d6 + pool.
- **28 • Sword-Bard** — *A blade-singer who bolsters allies and beguiles foes.* ↳ **Battle Hymn:** as your action, allies in Near get advantage and enemies in Near disadvantage on their next attack.

Caster

- **29 • Warlock** — *A pact-caster who hurls eldritch fire and calls servitors.* ↳ **Eldritch Blast:** signature cantrip — 1d10 force at Far, 0 mana; 1d12 while you have no mana left.
- **30 • Sorcerer** — *A wild innate caster who bends and amplifies their magic.* ↳ **Overcharge:** once per turn, spend 1 extra mana on a damage spell to maximize one of its dice.
- **31 • Mentalist** — *A mind-burning caster who shatters thought and body.* ↳ **Mind Spike** (1/rest): a creature in Near rolls Mind vs. your spell attack or is Stunned 1 round + takes 2d6 psychic.
- **32 • Templar** — *A militant healer who scourges foes and saves allies.* ↳ **Radiant Surge:** when you cast a Destruction spell, heal an ally in Near 1d6.
- **33 • Artificer** — *A maker who conjures tools, turrets, and constructs.* ↳ **Turret** (1/rest): conjure a construct (acts on your turn, ranged 1d8, 13 HP) for the encounter.
- **34 • Mage** — *The classic arcanist: summons, glamours, and clever control. (the old Mage)* ↳ **Arcane Recovery:** once per rest, regain 1d4 + level mana.
- **35 • Shaman** — *A spirit-speaker who calls ancestral aid and mends the tribe.* ↳ **Ancestral Spirit** (1/rest): summon a guardian (acts on your turn, melee 1d8, or heals an adjacent ally 1d6).
- **36 • Enchanter** — *A subtle manipulator of minds and matter.* ↳ **Dominate** (1/rest): a creature you've Charmed obeys one command — move + one action — on its turn.
- **37 • Priest** — *A devoted healer and warder of the faithful. (the old Priest)* ↳ **Intercession:** once per rest, when an ally in Near would drop to 0 HP, they drop to 1 instead and you heal them 1d6 + pool.
- **38 • Bard** — *A charismatic performer who inspires allies and bewitches foes.* ↳ **Inspiration** (free, 1+pool/rest): give an ally advantage on their next roll of any kind.

Full caster

- **39 • Elementalist** — *A master of raw elements — fire, frost, and stone.* ↳ **Attunement:** each turn choose fire (+1d6), frost (halve target Speed), or stone (+2 Armor to you) on your Destruction spells.
 - **40 • Archmage** — *The pinnacle arcanist — devastating and endlessly versatile.* ↳ **Spell Mastery:** choose one Lesser spell you know; once per rest, cast it without paying mana.
 - **41 • Necromancer** — *A death-mage who raises the fallen and drains the living.* ↳ **Raise Dead** (1/rest): raise a slain creature in Near as a thrall (acts on your turn, 1d8) for the encounter.
 - **42 • Spellmystic** — *A reality-warper blending force, fire, and falsehood.* ↳ **Warp:** once per round, as a free action, teleport up to Near range.
 - **43 • Oracle** — *A seer channeling divine foresight, wrath, and healing.* ↳ **Foresight:** once per round, force any creature in sight to reroll a d20; you pick which result stands.
 - **44 • Witch** — *A hedge-sorceress of curses, hexes, and old remedies.* ↳ **Curse:** mark a creature (free, 1/turn); it has disadvantage on defenses vs. your spells, which deal +1d6 against it.
 - **45 • Mystic** — *An enigmatic caster of wards, phantoms, and bound spirits.* ↳ **Astral Step** (1/rest): become incorporeal until your next turn — move through anything, can't be grappled, attacks vs. you have disadvantage.
 - **46 • Druid** — *A keeper of the wilds who shapes nature and calls beasts.* ↳ **Wild Shape** (1/rest): become a beast (GM's equivalent pick) up to 10 min; revert at your HP when it drops. 🌶️
 - **47 • Spiritualist** — *A medium who walks with spirits and mends through them.* ↳ **Possession** (1/rest): a willing ally in Near immediately takes a full extra turn, guided by a spirit. 🌶️
 - **48 • Seer** — *A prophet who sees the strands of fate and reweaves them.* ↳ **Ward of Fate:** once per round, when an ally in Near is hit, you may cause the attack to miss instead.
-

What this system doesn't have

- Subclasses or multiclassing (the combinations replace both).
- A separate martial resource pool (at-will weapons are the martial engine).
- A speed stat for armor (weight rule ③ handles it via tempo, not Speed).
- Per-class bespoke rules beyond your component tracks + 2 signatures.
- More than **3 components** on any build (the balance invariant — the 6 perks unlock from those 3 components over levels).

Balance Notes — Martials vs. Casters (Level 1)

A living design doc. Captures a balance analysis of the four base classes and the **guardrails to protect when expanding the catalog** (new classes, bigger spell roster, material tiers). Not a rule — a reference for whoever designs new content.

The question that prompted this: *"Casters have cantrips AND spells — doesn't that give them a greater number of actions than a Warrior or Scout?"*

Short answer: No. Action economy is flat (one action per turn for everyone). A cantrip is the caster's *at-will basic attack* — the equivalent of a sword swing — not a bonus action. And at the at-will level the martials hit ~3× harder. See below.

Reference builds (Human ancestry, +3/+2/+1/+0 array, starting kits)

Using Human for all four standardizes each at **primary +5** with a 4th training — apples-to-apples.

Warrior

- Might +5, Spirit +2, Agility +1, Mind +0 · **HP 15**
- **Armor 19** (Steel heavy: 10 + Might 5 + 4) · Mind 10 · Spirit 12
- Longsword +7 → **1d8+5** (avg 9.5) · Greatsword +7 → 1d10+5 (avg 10.5)
- Cleave · Bulwark (+1 Armor to adjacent allies)

Scout

- Agility +5, Mind +2, Might +1, Spirit +0 · **HP 9**
- **Armor 17** (Leather light: 10 + Agi 5 + 2) · Mind 12 · Spirit 10
- Longbow +7 → **1d8+5** (avg 9.5); +**1d6 Sneak Strike** → ~13, at Far range
- Sneak Strike · Slip Away

Mage

- Mind +5, Agility +2, Might +1, Spirit +0 · **HP 7**
- **Armor 12** (none) · Mind 15 · Spirit 10 · **Mana 6**
- Spark +7 → 1d6 (avg 3.5) · Daze +7 vs Mind → Stun
- Magic Missile (auto-hit 10.5) · Burning Hands (7/target cone) · Shield (reaction +5 Armor)
- Spellcasting · Arcane Recovery

Priest

- Spirit +5, Might +2, Agility +1, Mind +0 · **HP 10**
- **Armor 13** (Leather light: 10 + Agi 1 + 2) · Mind 10 · Spirit 15 · **Mana 6**
- Mace +4 → 1d8+2 (avg 6.5) · Sacred Flame +7 → 1d8 (avg 4.5)

- Cure Wounds (heal 14) · Healing Word (heal 8.5 at range, wakes downed) · Bless
- Divine Touch (heal 8.5, **6×/rest**) · Spellcasting

Comparison

	Warrior	Scout	Mage	Priest
HP	15	9	7	10
Armor	19	17	12	13
At-will dmg/turn	9.5	9.5–13	3.5	4.5–6.5
Burst (costs mana)	—	—	10.5 auto / 7-AoE	—
Sustain	∞	∞	~6 big turns → cantrips	∞ melee, 6 mana magic
Healing	—	—	—	only one
Control/disable	—	—	Daze, Sleep, Burning Hands	Bless (buff)
Actions per turn	1	1	1	1

The action-economy point (the crux)

Everyone gets one action per turn. A cantrip is not an extra action — it's the caster's at-will basic attack, costing 0 mana the same way a sword swing costs 0 resource. A Mage cannot cast a cantrip *and* a spell in one turn.

And the at-will damage favors martials heavily:

At-will attack	Avg dmg
Warrior longsword	9.5
Scout longbow (+sneak)	9.5–13
Mage Spark	3.5
Priest Sacred Flame	4.5

A caster out of mana does ~~1/3 a martial's damage from a body with half the HP~~. Casters buy a ~~menu~~ (burst, AoE, control, heal, utility), not extra **turns**, and the menu is rationed by mana (6 big plays, then back to weak cantrips).

Where "casters feel strong" actually comes from (mostly intended)

- Versatility, not volume** — a caster always has a meaningful option; a martial's answer is "I hit it." Breadth feels like more, but it's spent one action at a time.
- Burst & reliability** — Magic Missile can't miss; Burning Hands hits a cone; Sleep removes two enemies. Higher ceiling, lower floor, finite count.

3. **Healing monopoly** — only the Priest heals. Makes the Priest *mandatory*, which is a different problem from *overpowered*.

The levers that already balance it

-  **Flat action economy** — the single biggest anti-bloat rule. No bonus-action spells, no free cantrip-plus-spell turns, no general reaction slot. **Protect this above everything.**
-  **Mana scarcity + no short rest + hard-to-rest-mid-dungeon** — over a long day, martials' infinite output overtakes finite caster burst. The explicit balance knob.
-  **Fragility** — Mage at 7 HP / Armor 12 dies fast. Power bought with a glass jaw.
-  **Martial identity** — Cleave (the one legit "extra attack": chain KOs in one action), Bulwark (team defense aura), Sneak Strike (+1d6 every turn), best HP/Armor. Martials are the reliable, durable, infinite option.

Verdict

Not OP in the "more actions" sense — actions are flat and cantrips are a *weaker* basic attack, not a bonus turn. In raw combat, **martials lead on damage, durability, and sustain**; casters trade all three for **versatility + burst + (Priest) healing**. Classic, healthy fighter/caster tension; at level 1 it tilts *toward* the martials.

Two genuine soft spots to watch:

-  **Out-of-combat coverage** — casters cover more non-combat pillars (Arcana, Investigation, utility cantrips, Detect Magic, Comprehend Languages). This is where "casters do more" is true: exploration & problem-solving, not combat actions.
-  **Healing monopoly** — the Priest feels required.

⚠ Guardrails for expanding the catalog

When adding classes, spells, weapons, and armor (the "bigger roster" plan), the balance holds **only if**:

1. **One action per turn stays sacred.** Never print a bonus-action cast, a free off-turn cantrip, or any "cast a spell AND attack" feature. This is the rule that prevents 5e-style caster supremacy.
2. **Mana stays scarce.** No per-encounter refresh, no easy mid-dungeon rest, no mana batteries. Finite resources are why infinite martials keep pace.
3. **New martial classes get a reliable, infinite identity** of their own (a Cleave-equivalent, an aura, a consistent rider) — not just "hits things."
4. **Caster power scales by new options, not more actions or more resources per turn.** A bigger spell list widens the menu; it must not widen the turn.
5. **Watch the utility/pillar gap** — as the spell roster grows, casters gain more non-combat answers. Give martials and skill-focused classes their own exploration/social levers so they don't become combat-only.
6. **If healing spreads to more classes**, the Priest's "mandatory" pressure eases — a healthy change, but re-check that no class becomes a strictly-better healer.

The one-line guardrail: **a bigger catalog should widen the menu, never widen the turn.**

The component-class system (the realized catalog)

The "bigger roster" plan above shipped as the **48-class component system** (19-classes.md) + the school-tagged spell catalog (10-spell-list.md). This section records how it stays balanced and where it brushed against the guardrails.

The balance spine: 3 components, fixed unlock schedule

Every class — fighter, caster, or hybrid — is built from **exactly 3 components**, and grows on a **fixed schedule** (03-progression.md):

- **Build economy:** 2 component picks (weapon types / schools) + an armor tier = the baseline. **Going naked (no armor) buys a 3rd pick** but drops you to the lowest HP *and* lowest Armor. The budget is always **3 components**.
- **Each component is a 2-perk track** (basic + advanced), so the full kit is **6 perks**, unlocked one per perk-level (3/6/9/12/15/18). On top, every character has **2 Signatures** from level 1 (Racial + Class) and a level-20 **capstone**.
- This stays *checkable by counting*: a build is legal iff it lands on 3 components, and because the schedule is fixed, **every character of level N has the same number of abilities** (2 signatures + perks unlocked). No bespoke tuning per class.

Signature rule: the Class Signature (formerly the "override") must be $\approx$ **a perk in power** — unique, not stronger. The change from the old system: it's now a **standalone level-1 grant**, not a swap. Everyone gets it, uniformly, so relative balance is unchanged; the absolute floor rose slightly (you no longer pay a perk for it), which is the intended new baseline. **Advanced-rung perks and the Class-Signature ascensions are playtest items** — tuned to a strong veteran/master perk, watch they don't out-scale.

HP & survivability by armor tier

HP now rides the armor tier instead of a per-class number:

Tier	HP	Armor (lvl 1, primary +5)
Heavy	10 + Might	~19
Light	8 + Might	~15–17
None	6 + Might	~12

- **Naked classes are squishy in both HP and Armor** — that double-fragility is what *pays for* the extra pick. It's the glass-cannon tax that balances the 3-school full casters and the naked spellswords.
- **Casters gained durability:** light armor is now cast-friendly, so a standard caster sits at **8 + Might** HP / ~15 Armor instead of the old Mage's **6 / 12**. **Watch this** — it's a real buff to caster survivability; if casters feel too tanky, the lever is to push more of them toward the naked (3-school) tier or trim light-caster HP back to 6.

Where it tested the guardrails (and the fixes)

- **Guardrail #1 (one action — never "cast AND attack")**. The first draft of **Battlemage** had *Spell Burst* (weapon attack **plus** a cantrip same turn) — a direct violation. **Fixed** to *Runic Weapon* (an at-will +1d6 rider on weapon hits — widens the hit, not the turn). All other gish signatures (*Spellstrike*, *Divine Smite*, *Hex*, *Lifedrain*, *Psychic Lash*) are **riders on an attack you're already making**, not second actions — legal.
- **Guardrail #2 (mana stays scarce)**. *Archmage's Spell Mastery* was "a Lesser spell for 0 mana **once per round**" — effectively +mana every turn. **Fixed** to **once per rest**. A per-round free spell is the kind of resource-widening to refuse.
- **Guardrail #1, summons**. Conjunction adds bodies that attack — the classic action-economy bloat. Contained by the **summon leash**: a summon is *tethered* (acts right after your turn, no initiative slot) and **counts as your one ongoing spell** (09-magic.md), so you can field **only one**, and not alongside another ongoing spell. Summon class signatures (*Adept*, *Spellforged*, *Artificer*, *Shaman*, *Necromancer*) obey the same leash.
- **Guardrail #3 (martial get an infinite identity)**. Component perks deliver it: every weapon carries a reliable rider (*Cleave*, *Sneak Strike*, *Deadeye*, *Riposte*) and armor carries *Bulwark/Slip Away*. Fighters keep at-will weapons as their engine; no martial resource pool was added.

Remaining watch-items (playtest)

- 🍄 **Druid — Wild Shape** and **Spiritualist — Possession** (grants a full extra ally turn) are the two spiciest Class Signatures. Once-per-rest contains them; re-check they don't dominate.
- 🩹 **Healing spread**. Restoration is now reachable by many classes (*Priest*, *Templar*, *Shaman*, *Bard*, *Cleric-Knight*, *Acolyte*, *Paladin*, *Oracle*, *Necromancer*, *Druid*, *Seer*, *Spiritualist*...). This *eases* the old "Priest mandatory" problem (good) — verify no class becomes a strictly-better healer than another at equal investment.
- 📖 **Uniform mana**. Every caster tier uses `level + pool`, regardless of 1, 2, or 3 schools. Breadth and survivability differentiate them, not fuel. If a 1-school half-caster's reliability + weapon makes it outshine the squishy 3-school full caster, the knob is school-count-scaled spells-known or a small mana bump for the committed casters.

Heavy gear & the single-primary rule (two holes closed)

Two structural holes were found and fixed after the first roster draft:

- **Armor had no real cost** — heavy strictly beat light for fighters (its only downside, "no casting," is free to a non-caster). Fixed *without a Speed stat* by **Set to Strike** (move + attack in heavy gear → disadvantage; heavy weapon *and* heavy armor → move-or-attack) plus **no ranged weapons in heavy armor**. Heavy = immovable, kiteable, can't shoot; light = mobile; none = +1 perk but fragile. The same tempo rule gives **heavy weapons** a genuine drawback vs. medium (plant to swing, on top of two-handed/no-shield). This also auto-pruned the heavy-armor-archer classes: **51 → 48**.
- **Gish were MAD** — weapon stat (Might/Agility) ≠ spell stat (pool), so every hybrid was half-weak. Fixed by the **single-primary rule**: one ability powers *all* attacks, weapon and spell. A Mind-Battlemage's blade and fire both scale off Mind. This makes the naked 2-school **Spellsword** coherent (lightly built is fine —

it's a caster that strikes with magic), which is what lets the **3-perk invariant** stand: *weapon + 2 schools + armor = 4 perks is illegal*, so a 2-school gish stays naked and an armored gish takes only 1 school.

- ⚠ Watch: single-primary removes the old MAD tax, so gish got *better*. Their remaining cost is fewer schools and/or no armor — re-check in play that they don't eclipse pure martials or pure casters.

The spine: **every build is 3 components (2 signatures + 6 perks over levels); one primary powers everything; heavy gear trades mobility for protection; nothing ever widens the turn.**

Charisma — the fifth ability (and fourth defense)

A later pass added **Charisma** as a fifth ability and a third caster pool, alongside Mind and Spirit. The goal: a clean home for *innate* magic (sorcery, pact, song) and for social play, without adding any new economy.

What changed, and why it's balance-neutral

- **Five abilities, array +3/+2/+1/+1/+0** (was +3/+2/+1/+0 over four). One extra +1 compensates for the extra stat to cover — characters still have a +0 dump. The **math ceiling is unchanged**: max +3 at creation → +5 after bumps, so d20 + 9 stands for the whole game.
- **A fourth defense, 10 + Charisma**. The three caster abilities are now fully symmetric: each is both a *pool* and a *defense*. This is the one place the change adds complexity (a fourth number on every sheet and stat block) — an accepted trade for symmetry.
- **The three pools are mechanically identical** (level + pool). Charisma is not stronger or weaker than Mind/Spirit; it differs only in *which defense the caster naturally has high* and in flavor (studied / devoted / innate). So re-tagging 10 classes to Charisma changed **no class's power** — only its high defense and its dump-stat exposure.

The defense re-carve (the only real design choice)

For a Charisma *defense* to matter, effects had to target it. The carve:

- **Mind** — hijacks cognition: illusion, sleep, psychic, paralysis (*Hold Person*), domination (*Dominate Mind*).
- **Charisma** — bends the heart/will: **charm and fear** (*Charm Person*, *Fear*, *Terror* moved here from Mind).
- **Spirit** — assaults the soul/life: banishment, death-magic, possession, holy wrath.

This keeps each of the four defenses live (see the *All four defenses see fire* note in 10-spell-list.md). The Dwarf trait (*Stone-Hearted*) was repointed from Spirit→Charisma to match (fear/charm now resisted by Charisma).

Watch-items

- ⚖️ **Charm/fear concentration on one defense**. Only three spells target Charisma today. That's thin but fine — it makes a high-Charisma caster's *own* Charisma defense quietly valuable, and the future signature/spell expansion (Points 5/magic) can add command/taunt/beguile effects there. Keep new charm/fear/command effects pointed at Charisma so the defense stays meaningful.
 - 🗣️ **Social rolls now key off Charisma** by default (04-skills-and-checks.md). This gives Charisma-pool casters (Bard, Sorcerer, Warlock...) a natural out-of-combat pillar — the same versatility lever other casters already enjoy, not a new power.
 - 📖 **Stat-block churn**. Every monster now carries a Charisma defense ($\approx$ Spirit, nudged: leaders/fiends/fey up, mindless down). Mindless undead/constructs are still *immune* to charm/fear, so their low number rarely bites.
-

Level 20 & the progression ladder

The cap moved **10** → **20**, with a three-beat ladder (*Ability* → *Perk* → *Breadth*) and the perk/signature split (03-progression.md). What protects balance across the longer track:

- 📖 **The accuracy ceiling is frozen.** Training bonus caps at **+4** and any ability at **+5**, so the top attack/check total stays **d20 + 9** — and is reached around the veteran tier, never rising after. **Levels 8–20 add tools and HP, not bigger to-hit numbers.** This is the single rule that keeps a doubled level range from breaking monster math. Bounded accuracy is non-negotiable; if a future feature would raise the ceiling, it's the feature that's wrong.
- ⚖️ **Tiers rescaled, not renumbered:** Apprentice 1–7 · Veteran 8–14 · Master 15–20. Materials, training bonus, monster tiers, and spell-tier access all still key off these three bands; only the level spans widened.
- 🗡️ **Martial ↔ caster parity on the breadth beat.** Each breadth level gives a caster **+1** spell or a non-caster **+1** training — parallel currencies, so neither half pulls ahead in growth count. Martials end up broadly skilled (≈ 9 trainings), casters spell-deep (9 known); that's the intended divergence, not an imbalance.
- 📖 **Mana runs deep at high level** ($\text{level} + \text{pool} \rightarrow \sim 25$ at L20). Watch-item, but bounded by three things: **spells known cap at 9**, the **adventuring day is long** (3–5 fights/rest), and **one ongoing spell at a time**. If a caster's day-long mana lets them trivialize single fights, the lever is a soft mana cap or a per-fight throttle — not touched for now.
- 💪 **HP roughly doubles by L20** (~ 175 heavy / ~ 110 naked). Monster *damage* scales within tier to match (see the scaling note in 12-monsters.md); monster *to-hit* does not (frozen ceiling). Re-check that master-tier fights don't drag against bloated HP — the fix is always more monster damage, never more monster accuracy.

The extended spine: **3 components** → **2 signatures** + **6 perks** + **a capstone, on a fixed schedule; numbers freeze at the veteran tier; the back half of the game is breadth, not bigger dice.**